NOV. 9, 2026

The AI Election

What's Charging the Data-Center Revolt | BY NAOMI NIX

TIME

TIME

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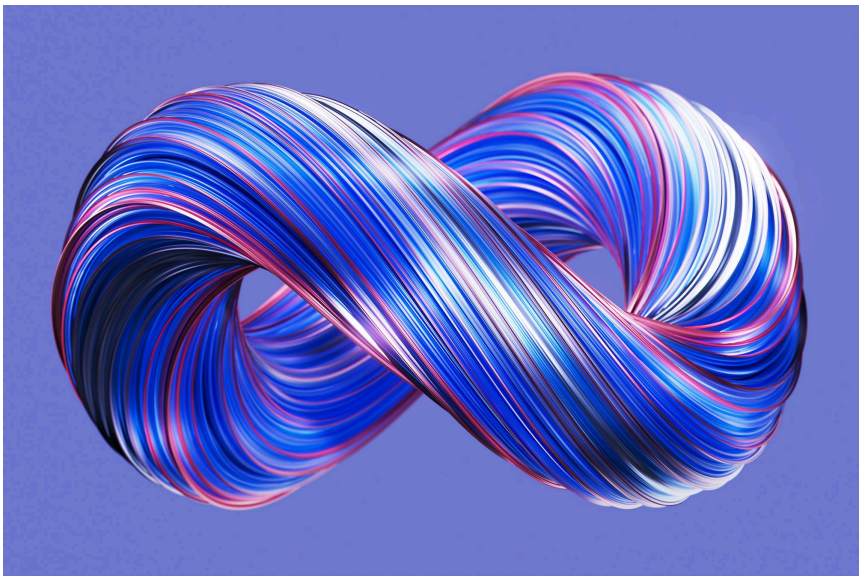
- **A New Report Sheds Light on the Secretive Race to Build Self-Improving AI**
  As AI companies warn of the dangers of self-improving AI, a new report offers a rare look at how they’re working to make it a reality.

Business | AI

A New Report Sheds Light on the Secretive Race to Build Self-Improving AI



Eugene Mymrin/Getty Images

For months, Anthropic and OpenAI have warned that AI may be on the verge of improving itself.

This tipping point, known as “recursive self-improvement,” or RSI, could mean that new AI capabilities arrive faster than ever. But the advent of RSI might also be highly perilous for humanity, potentially marking the stage at which developers lose control of AI systems entirely.

Even as AI companies warn about the potential dangers of RSI, they have shared remarkably little about how they’re pursuing it. A new report, published Wednesday by the firm Gladstone AI, attempts to change that. It gives one of the most detailed pictures yet of how RSI could work and how AI companies are progressing toward it. The report is based on what the authors say are

conversations with half a dozen researchers inside the top AI companies.

The report, exclusively shared with TIME ahead of its publication, emphasizes that AI companies are "actively working on" automating all parts of the AI development pipeline, including generating new ideas, running experiments to test those ideas, and interpreting the results. Most of the insiders Gladstone spoke to "believe RSI will start within the next 3 to 12 months, and possibly sooner, assuming there's no U.S. government intervention or slowdown," the report states.

Read More: *Inside the Race to Make AI Build Itself*

"There's a fair amount of [disaster] prepping and bio-bunker purchasing going on" among these researchers, says Edouard Harris, Gladstone's chief technology officer.

The aim of the report, Gladstone's executives tell TIME, is to give lawmakers a better understanding of how RSI works, and, in turn, a greater ability to regulate it.

"Our goal here was to define recursive self-improvement well enough that people can have a sane conversation about it, especially in Washington," says Jeremie Harris, Gladstone's CEO. (The pair are brothers.) "There are all these bills proposed to ban superintelligence, which are really interesting attempts to grapple with this problem. But what we're more interested in is: what is the process that needs to be regulated?"

How RSI could work

The report gives a simplified outline of how the AI research pipeline currently operates inside AI companies—and how those companies are beginning to automate the process.

For the first phase of training an AI model, known as pretraining, much of the emphasis is on finding ways to squeeze more intelligence out of a model with less and less computing power, known in the industry as “compute.”

The AI companies take a portfolio approach to testing these ideas. Researchers allocate a small amount of compute to each idea, using it to train a series of models. The models that reliably perform better as they scale up are selected for another round of training, using larger amounts of compute.

Companies don’t have infinite compute, which limits the number of promising ideas they can test at larger scales. This means that even if AI companies can train an AI that is able to generate ideas that seem promising, it matters greatly how many bad ideas it generates simultaneously. If companies need to spend huge amounts of time or compute filtering good AI-generated ideas from bad ones, it might make sense to continue to rely on human researchers with sound intuition.

Conversely, AI companies with access to more compute are able to test more ideas—potentially allowing them to reach RSI first. With more compute to throw at experiments, companies may also be likelier to catch ideas that the Gladstone report describes as the rarest and most desired by AI companies: those that perform *better* as more compute is thrown at them, even if they appear to be duds at smaller scales.

Being able to tell when those ideas are found—and particularly whether AI is helping find them—“is just such a critical part of this process that right now legislators have essentially zero visibility into,” says Jeremie Harris.

One of the traits that makes regulating RSI tricky is that it is a gradual process. “This is actually one of the reasons why we went to pains to describe it in so much detail,” says Edouard Harris. “So

that it is possible to point to a part of this process and say: a human *needs* to be there.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/14/recursive-self-improvement-AI-report/

Climate

- **Ohio’s Data-Center Revolt Is Upending the Midterms**
  In conservative Ohio, the pushback against data centers may propel Democrats at the polls.
- **Climate Change Is Accelerating Faster Than We Can Respond, Scientists Warn**
  “Earth’s climate system is moving deeper into uncharted territory,” scientists warn.

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Climate | AI

Ohio’s Data-Center Revolt Is Upending the Midterms

Patty Spillman’s farm in Grove City, Ohio, abuts the site of a proposed 310-acre data centerMaddie McGarvey for TIME

Story

by

Naomi Nix

Patty Spillman’s farm in Grove City, Ohio, abuts the site of a proposed 310-acre data center Maddie McGarvey for TIME

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Narrated by TIME AI.

Patty Spillman and Jen Belt drive through the outskirts of Grove City, Ohio, mapping the battle lines of a war they've waged for months. Pointing out the window of Belt's blue Chrysler mini-van, Spillman notes the precise borders of a proposed 310-acre data-center campus. She singles out the electrical substation and towering power lines, and recounts the personal histories of neighbors who got offers to sell their land to Headwaters Site Development, the Texas-based company proposing to construct a cloud-computing storage facility on this patch of rural farmland about 10 miles outside Columbus. In between fields of drying corn-stalks and short rows of soybeans, some farmers have planted "no data center" signs on their lawns.

Spillman's 165-year-old farm sits across the street from the proposed complex. A soft-spoken retired bus driver, Spillman, 63, is a Republican who voted for President Donald Trump three times. Belt, a 51-year-old artist and marketing contractor, is a Democrat. For months, they've co-led a group called Protect Grove City, which mobilized a community effort to thwart the proposed data center. The residents' concerns are legion: water usage, noise and environmental concerns, energy costs, the cloak of secrecy hanging over the project. "This is our community. What if we don't want you here?" says Spillman, whose mother-in-law turned down an above-market offer from Headwaters of around $1.5 million for 30 acres of land.

Community pushback prompted the Grove City council to pass a yearlong moratorium on data-center construction. In November, Grove City residents will vote on a proposal to go even further, making all large developments subject to voter approval. The issue has upended the intimate politics of this conservative community of

45,180. Community Facebook groups are filled with bickering, angry residents have filled council meetings, and activists filed freedom-of-information requests seeking answers about city officials' communications about the referendum. Grove City's longtime mayor, Richard "Ike" Stage, and other local leaders have fought against their efforts, saying the ballot initiative to restrict development would hurt economic growth.

TIME illustration (Source image: Wong Yu Liang–Getty Images)

The fervor against data centers is spreading across the state. Ohio has some 200 data centers, making it one of the biggest hubs in the country. In a former swing state that went red in the Trump era, Republicans admit the groundswell of political opposition to data

centers has created a political opening for Ohio Democrats in the upcoming midterm elections.

“I’m as Republican as they get, but it’s going to be a tough year for Republicans in the state of Ohio,” says Nick Owens, a former county GOP chair and Trump delegate at the 2024 Republican National Convention. Owens is now working with the anti-data-center group Conserve Ohio. “I can get on my phone right now and text or call 10 or 12 people from 10 different corners of the state, from all different political backgrounds, from all different socio-economic backgrounds,” Owens says, “because we’re all united about this.”

A national Gallup poll published in May found that more than 70% of voters oppose building an AI data center in their area. In Ohio, where the average household’s electric bill climbed some 15% in the past year and more than 66% over the past decade, the sentiment is even more negative. A September survey by Bowling Green State University found that nearly 80% of Ohioans support a moratorium on data centers. More than 100 local governments in Ohio have reportedly enacted data-center moratoriums; in November, at least 10 will vote on adding a data-center ban to their charters, while two others will decide whether to recall mayors who cut data-center deals. In the eyes of opponents, the facilities—and the powerful AI industry that backs them—have come to represent an attack on their safety, jobs, pocketbooks, and quality of life.

Patty SpillmanMaddie McGarvey for TIME

Jen Belt, Spillman and Belt lead Protect Grove City, which fights the Headwaters projectMaddie McGarvey for TIME

It’s not clear just how potent the issue will be at the polls in November. By themselves, data centers don’t rank as a top-tier national campaign issue, according to voters—in a recent Pew Research Center survey, the economy, the future of democracy, health care, education, and immigration made up the top five. But Democratic candidates have sought to connect data centers to many of those themes. They’re promising to ease affordability concerns by cracking down on high electricity bills through data-center restrictions, pledging to strengthen democracy by fighting Silicon Valley’s opaque deals to get facilities built, casting AI companies as puppet masters in an unequal economy, and painting their political rivals as corrupt leaders seeking to curry favor from powerful companies. This election cycle, $137.6 million has been spent on

broadcast ads about data centers, with Democrats making up 77% of that estimated spending, according to the analytics firm AdImpact.

Some Democrats believe data centers could be a decisive issue in tight races, especially in red states like Texas, Iowa, and Ohio. In those states and others, voters have told pollsters they trust Democrats more on the issue. President Donald Trump has positioned himself as one of the industry's biggest champions, deriding opponents of data centers as "backwards and poor." The wave of populist anger has "become the one thing that unites Americans right now," says Megan Mullin, a UCLA political-science professor. "They connect to bigger themes that are becoming really important in American politics—around affordability, around energy affordability, around suspicion and discomfort about AI, about populist resistance to the accumulation of wealth and tech titans."

In early October, Don Leonard, the Democratic candidate in Ohio's 15th Congressional District, arrives at the Schmidlapp Free School Library in Piqua. The space is decorated for fall with artificial flowers, and filled with activists and community leaders ready to detail the latest data-center controversy.

Meta, which has been rapidly building out its data-center infrastructure to fuel its AI push, made plans to erect a $1 billion campus in the area. The company hashed out the deal in secret last year, according to city documents and news reports, using a private LLC and nondisclosure agreements with local officials. After Meta was outed as the company behind the data center, the social media giant and Piqua government officials said the project would bring economic investment to the region. In a statement, Meta told TIME the company is reviewing its use of nondisclosure agreements.

Leonard heard from Alisha Lange, 42, who worried about contamination of her well water. Lange, a registered Republican, was among those angered by the secrecy surrounding the project and revelations that several city officials had been awarded $3,000 bonuses by the city after winning Meta's business. In response, outraged residents successfully petitioned to add a measure to the November ballot designed to recall Piqua's mayor and other elected officials.

Don Leonard leads a round table discussion about data centers in Piqua, Ohio on Oct. 7Maddie McGarvey for TIME

A former city and regional planning professor at The Ohio State University, Leonard, 48, sports a stubbly beard and speaks with a deliberate unpretentiousness. Normally, a progressive candidate wouldn't stand much of a shot in a congressional district that's been represented by Republicans for the past 15 years. The incumbent, former coal-industry lobbyist Mike Carey, won by 13 points two years ago. But by the time Leonard won the primary in May, residents in the district, which includes Grove City, were aflame over data centers. Leonard pushed his team to add a data-center question to their polling. They found more than 70% of likely voters in the 15th District wanted greater say over where data centers are located and how they operate. "If we were going to message on it, we had to confirm quantitatively what we knew from listening to the constituents," Leonard explains in an

interview at a modern co-working space in Columbus. “Which is that data centers are one of the most bipartisan issues in Central Ohio right now.”

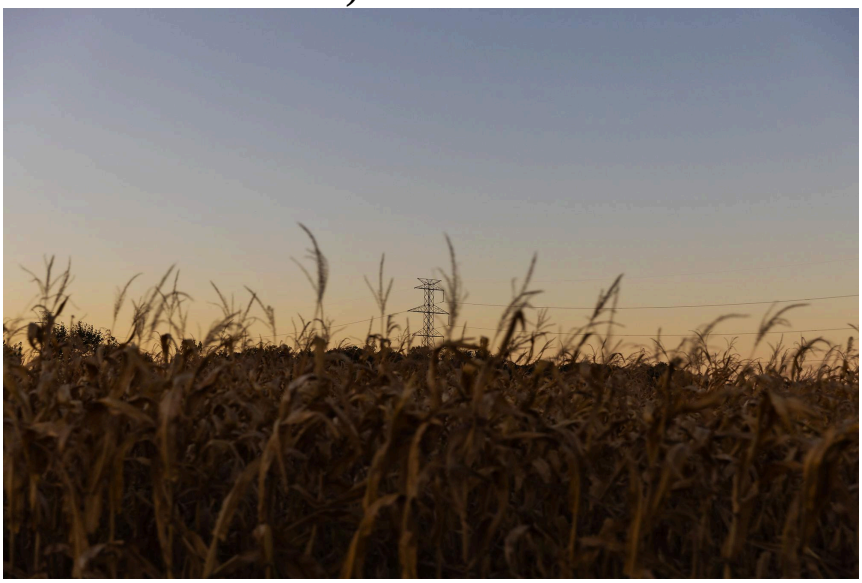
Leonard sees data centers as “the mascot for predatory capitalism,” forcing communities to absorb increased electricity costs and environmental threats as their local landscapes are remade by huge companies based far away. He says the developments have exacerbated the anxieties of residents who watched neighbors lose solid factory jobs to outsourcing and suspect they’ll once again be the losers in an AI-driven economy. “There’s a feeling like we didn’t even govern the last revolution—globalization—and now they’re hoisting another one on us,” Leonard says. “They’re doing it in our backyard. They’re attacking our way of life.”

It’s not clear whether the backlash will be enough to catapult Leonard into contention in a solidly Republican district. There has been no non-partisan polling in the race, nor any public debates, and Carey holds a clear fundraising advantage, raking in $4 million to Leonard’s $1.2 million, according to campaign filings, though a recent influx of spending against Leonard is a sign Republicans may be a little nervous.

But in other races in Ohio, Democrats spy a clear opportunity.

On a crisp fall day, Sherrod Brown takes the microphone during a small rally outside a Franklin County strip mall. He begins with talking points about economic inequality that he could have fed this crowd of Democratic organizers and voters at any point during his 18 years representing the state in the Senate. But then Brown pivots to an attack line that might have landed with a thud even a year ago. “These data centers are in Ohio now thanks to Jon Husted,” Brown says of his Republican opponent. “They come into communities. They gulp up the land. They swallow the water. Then they get these huge tax breaks.”

After three terms in Washington, Brown was defeated in 2024, when Trump won Ohio for the third straight time. The cornerstone of his comeback bid this year has been the data-center issue. In stump speeches, social media posts, and advertisements blaring across television, Brown blames Husted for the role he played as lieutenant governor in fostering data-center growth in the state, which gave data centers an estimated $2.5 billion in incentives, including breaks on sales and property taxes, from 2017 to 2024, according to a report by the Ohio Chamber of Commerce. (The report also estimates that the centers brought in twice as much in revenue to the state's coffers.)



Power lines run along a cornfield at the site of a proposed data center development in Grove CityMaddie McGarvey for TIME

Back then, Husted, like other political leaders in both parties, often celebrated tech companies like Google and Amazon, which built the sprawling campuses, as a boost to Ohio's economy. Husted campaign spokesperson Amy Natoce called Brown's critiques hypocritical, noting that in 2015 the former Senator himself praised an Amazon Web Services data-center project in Ohio, calling it "great news."

Now Husted is playing defense on the issue, sponsoring a Senate bill designed to get data centers to pay for electrical-system upgrades that was ultimately blocked by Democrats. Data centers

should be a local decision, he says. Polls show the race as a toss-up. But a recent New York *Times*/Siena poll found that Ohio was one of five right-leaning states—Alaska, Iowa, Kansas, and Texas are the others—where Democrats are outperforming expectations in Senate races, in part because voters said they thought the Democratic candidate would do a better job on data centers.

The party is eager to press that advantage. Dr. Amy Acton, the Democratic candidate for Ohio governor, has called for a conditional moratorium on data centers until they meet certain requirements, such as covering the cost of their own electricity, meeting environmental standards, and participating in community-benefit agreements. Vivek Ramaswamy, the Republican nominee, wants to force hyperscale data centers to cover electricity costs and abide by air- and water-quality standards. Acton has assailed Ramaswamy for not committing to selling off his investments in tech and AI stocks, calling these holdings a conflict of interest.

A similar pattern is playing out in other states. In Texas, both Democratic Senate nominee James Talarico and his Republican opponent Ken Paxton have proposed tighter restrictions on data centers and accused each other of being supported by tech-aligned donors. The state's Republican governor Greg Abbott, who is locked in a surprisingly tight race of his own, has imposed a temporary moratorium on new data centers until an audit is complete. In Iowa, data centers have been a flash point in the race between Democratic Senate nominee Josh Turek and Republican nominee Ashley Hinson, with Turek proposing restrictions and Hinson emphasizing the need for local control.

Ike Stage first became the mayor of Grove City in 1988. A retired banker who helped set up the local chamber of commerce, he credits cheapish land, a convenient location, and a business-friendly climate for the steady stream of calls he's fielded from developers over the years. Companies like medical manufacturer

American Nitrile have moved in, along with three hospitals and two scientific-research facilities. “Not many cities can say that,” Stage says in an interview at city hall, where brightly colored maps of the area adorn the walls.

Stage has aspirations for Grove City to grow further. In 2018, it adopted a vision that included better transportation options, more parks, and mixed-use developments. Officials also eyed more than 9,000 acres of agricultural and vacant land they thought could be turned into “light industrial-style development.”

Seven years later, Headwaters Site Development, founded by former Google data-center infrastructure leader Michael Lebow, had a similar thought. It contacted property owners in a rural area just south of Grove City’s limits. One of the homesteads belonged to Patty Spillman’s family, which rejected the deal. “Most of us turned them down,” Spillman says. But not all. By this spring, Headwaters had found enough homeowners willing to sell to cobble together the necessary land.

Mayor Richard Stage opposes putting major new development projects up for referendumMaddie McGarvey for TIME

During two information sessions at a local food bank in April, Headwaters representatives pitched locals on what they called Project Maple. Headwaters says it plans to sell the $6.9 billion project to an unidentified tech company, and pledged to support

community-friendly zoning requirements that would be assumed by the buyer, such as a 100-ft. height limit, concealing landscaping, and noise levels that aren't louder than a dishwasher. Headwaters says the project would bring 250 permanent jobs, pay for its own energy costs, and take precautions to keep water usage low. But according to advocates, Head-waters' refusal to say which tech company would ultimately buy the facility was unnerving. "They just skirted around giving us straight answers about anything," Jen Belt recalls. "A lot of people left mad."

The anger emboldened the activists. Belt circulated a petition calling for the city council to reject any upcoming data-center applications. The group posted negative information about the facilities on their personal social media pages, as well as in popular Facebook groups, and put up no data centers signs near the proposed site.

The following month, Grove City councilman Mohamed Omar, 26, announced he was working on legislation to impose a 12-month moratorium on local data centers. Headwaters responded by sending a letter to city council members, arguing that such a moratorium could violate its due process rights. (Lebow says the company has no plans to sue.)

Yet the implied legal threat intensified the community pushback against the project on the eve of the moratorium vote. In June, the moratorium passed 6-1. Emboldened, the anti-data-center advocates with Protect Grove City decided the one-year moratorium wasn't enough, and wrote a proposed amendment to the city's charter, which functions like a governing constitution. It would prohibit the city from approving zoning applications for developments that occupy at least 50 acres, use more than 20 megawatts of power at peak capacity, or consume more than 500,000 gallons of water per day unless a majority of voters have backed the project in a public referendum. To drum up support, they canvassed local farmers' markets, parks, and sporting events

to ask people to sign a petition to put the measure on the ballot in November. Within a few weeks, they secured enough signatures.

Councilman Mohamed Omar, who opposes data center development, in Grove CityMaddie McGarvey for TIME

City officials nervously tracked news coverage of the data-center backlash across Ohio and beyond, according to emails obtained by TIME. The charter amendment wouldn’t just inhibit the Headwaters project, they warned. It would fundamentally change how any future development deals are approved, and perhaps inhibit existing organizations, including churches, a hospital, and schools, from expanding by imposing overly burdensome processes. Critics contend residents already have opportunities to weigh in on upcoming developments through the normal city approval process. “It’s going to affect business. It’s going to affect

our schools. It’s going to affect our taxes,” says Steve Funk, 70, who runs a car dealership in Grove City.

The city has been sending mailers to residents explaining the amendment’s potential effects. Residents have gotten into bitter personal disputes over the amendment in Facebook groups. “It’s bad,” says Omar. “It almost feels like the city is torn.”

To Stage, tech companies have done a poor job trumpeting the benefits the facilities bring to local communities, allowing residents’ anxieties about the industry to flourish. He likens the backlash to the fears Americans had about railroad expansion during the 19th century, when rural farmers worried about the effect the technology might have on their livestock. Americans eventually got used to trains. But Stage also recognizes that he’s on the short side of public opinion. Stage is up for re-election next year. “I’ve won most elections pretty handily, and I’ve been through 11 of them,” he says. “But you never, never make that assumption.” —*With reporting by Leslie Dickstein*

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/29/ohio-data-center-revolt-upending-midterms/

Climate | Science

Climate Change Is Accelerating Faster Than We Can Respond, Scientists Warn

A firefighter sprays a hotspot while fighting the Bike fire in the outskirts of Santa Clarita, California on Oct. 11, 2026.David Swanson—Getty Images

The climate is warming up faster than we can respond. According to a new report published Oct. 14 in the journal *BioScience*, "Earth's climate system is moving deeper into uncharted territory."

The State of the Climate, an annual report that tracks the Earth's "vital signs," monitors several climate related indicators—ranging from greenhouse gas concentrations and temperature changes to tree cover loss due to wildfire. The researchers found that, of the 16 planetary vital signs, seven are currently at record extremes. This includes sea levels and greenhouse gasses in the atmosphere. Meanwhile several others, such as areas burned during wildfires and ocean heat levels, show evidence of acceleration or abrupt shifts.

The researchers warn that the rate of global warming appears to have accelerated, from about 0.05°C per decade between 1880 and

1970 to roughly 0.36°C per decade between 2010 and 2024—and the 2°C threshold meant to limit planetary damage could be reached before 2050 they warn. These accelerating and intensifying changes could raise the risk of reinforcing feedback loops and crossing tipping points—critical thresholds that, when crossed, can lead to accelerating and often irreversible environmental changes. In 2025, the Earth passed its first climate tipping point, as rising ocean temperatures, acidification, overfishing, and pollution are combining to cause coral bleaching and mortality.

"Earth's life-support systems are being pushed beyond stable limits," the report states, "with changes unfolding faster than our ability to respond."

This year, a number of extreme weather events made the impacts of an acceleratingly warming planet impossible to ignore. July 2026 was the hottest month on record for the contiguous United States, with ocean temperatures also reaching a record high that month. Back-to-back heat waves in Europe lead to an estimated 35,000 excess deaths, preliminary reports show. A number of regions—including Utah in the U.S., Ontario, Canada, along with France, Spain, Britain, and Belgium have either experienced their worst wildfire years in history or are on track to do so. While we don't yet know enough to link these individual weather events to climate change, research shows that it is supercharging extreme weather events.

Concentrations of greenhouse gases—including carbon dioxide, methane, and nitrous oxide—all reached record levels in 2026, the researchers say. In May 2026, atmospheric carbon dioxide exceeded 428 parts per million, roughly 50% above pre-industrial levels and generally higher than any time in the last 2 million years.

The authors of today's report also tracked indicators of the human activities driving these planetary changes, like energy use, food production, and economic growth. Fossil fuel consumption remains

the dominant driver of these changes. Fossil fuel consumption rose by 0.9% in 2025, the report found, with oil, coal, and gas all reaching record highs, and annual energy-related carbon dioxide emissions surpassed 41 gigatons for the first time—the equivalent of emissions released by over 10,800 coal-fired power plants in one year.

There have, however, been some signs of progress, the report notes. Low-carbon sources provided roughly 43% of global electricity generation in 2025, and solar and wind energy consumption grew by approximately 18%. That was before the war in Iran laid bare the world's reliance on fossil fuels, and triggered a global green energy boom.

But cutting carbon emissions will no longer be enough on its own, the report states. Adaptation measures—ranging from shifts towards plant-based diets, to restoring mangroves to better protect against storm surges—will be key to adjusting to a changing climate.

The report underscores an unavoidable truth. "We are witnessing the rapid destabilization of the Earth's climate system," it states. "This is no longer a warning for the future; it is a diagnosis of the present."

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/14/climate-change-accelerating-study/

Entertainment

- **I've Been Disabled Since I Was a Child. Co-WritingBeing HeumannStill Taught Me So Much**
  Rebekah Taussig on the depicting and defending Judy Heumann's work
- **John Malkovich and Sam Rockwell Are Pure Delight in Martin McDonagh'sWild Horse Nine**
  Like 'In Bruges' and 'The Banshees of Inisherin,' McDonagh's latest, about 1970s CIA agents sent to Easter Island, deals with fractious male friendships
- **Lee Chang Dong'sPossible LoveIs a Delicate Drama of Love and Longing in Anxious Times**
  The filmmaker behind 'Burning' traces the interconnected stories of two couples across the class divide.
- **NocturneIs a Slow-Burning Crime Drama That Struggles to Stay Lit**
  Liev Schreiber and Zazie Beetz play mind games with a serial killer in Apple's prestige murder pastiche.
- **The One About Matthew PerryIs More Than the Typical Saga of Fame and Addiction**
  This three-part Netflix doc takes an honest, empathetic look at the troubled 'Friends' star and the addiction that dominated his adult life.
- **John Turturro Will Pick Your Pocket and Steal Your Heart**
  The veteran New York actor on playing an honorable pickpocket, how his hometown has changed, and his love of dance and basketball.

Entertainment | movies

I've Been Disabled Since I Was a Child. Co-Writing *Being Heumann* Still Taught Me So Much

Ruth Madeley stars as the titular character in 'Being Heumann'Apple

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Narrated by TIME AI.

The night before an airline lost my wheelchair was among the most dazzling of my life. I sat at a long table in the back of an L.A. movie theater as talented writers, actors, and creatives read aloud

the draft of a movie script I'd co-written with Oscar-winning filmmaker Siân Heder. I felt the thrill of people laughing at just the right moments. I clocked cheeks shiny with tears. But more than anything, I marveled over the possibility that this movie might actually get made. When I was a newly paralyzed kid in the '90s, with freshly fitted leg braces, I watched Forrest Gump overcome his disability by running so hard his own braces literally fell off. Months after I started college, I watched a recently disabled boxer ask her coach to end her life in *Million Dollar Baby.* In my formative years, the stories of disability I saw were scarce, unrecognizable, and often harmful.

Our script, *Being Heumann*, tells the real-life David and Goliath story of a standoff between the U.S. government and a group of scrappy disabled protesters that changed the course of American history. The fight revolved around Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, a tiny bit of legislation that reframed how we think about disability in our communities. Instead of positioning its embodiment as a personal tragedy that inevitably excludes people from society, the language of 504 suggested that our exclusion had been largely created and should be corrected. The law passed in 1973, but after years without any moves to implement it, Judy Heumann led over 100 disabled people and nondisabled allies in a sit-in at the Department of Health, Education, and Welfare in San Francisco. They lived in those halls for almost a month as the government tried to push them out, cutting off their water supply and phone lines. When it became clear that they weren't going to buckle, the government relented, agreeing to implement 504. The very group that had been deemed expendable took on the most powerful and won. It still holds the place as the longest peaceful occupation of a federal building in U.S. history.

Section 504 paved the way for the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), the first civil rights law for disabled people in the world. Thanks in large part to disabled WW II vet and my Kansas Senator, Bob Dole, it passed in 1990 with nearly unanimous bipartisan

support and was signed into law by President George H.W. Bush when I was 4 years old. Even if they're not consistently or completely fulfilled, these laws changed our world in their insistence that physical and mental impairment alone should not and would not preclude us from participating in our communities—going to school; voting; receiving care in a hospital; being considered for a job for which we're qualified; and accessing our libraries, post offices, public transit, housing, and more. In other words, Section 504 and the ADA protect every American citizen; if there is one thread that binds us together, it is that every single one of us will acquire a disability if we live long enough. Still, I, like most Americans, never heard a whisper of this history growing up.

It wasn't until I worked on this script that my perspective considerably expanded. It was like putting on a pair of night-vision goggles: the curb cuts, accessible bathroom stalls, and ramps radiated a new story. Someone had fought for me to be here. It didn't wipe out the inaccessibility and stigma that still exist in my life, but it enriched my understanding of the bigger story I was living inside.

When I first joined the *Being Heumann* project, I was nervous about earning Judy's trust. I remember sitting in my car, phone pressed against my sweaty ear, as she asked me questions about my life. "So you went to school with your siblings?" My attendance at the school down the street from my house was never a question, while Judy's mother battled for years to get her daughter a spot in even a basement classroom. "And what was it like for you applying for teaching positions?" My wheelchair was never mentioned in job interviews, while Judy was denied a teaching license because her wheelchair was deemed a fire hazard. Recapping my life to The Judy Heumann, I saw more clearly than ever before how she and other activists had shaped it. Even as I'd sat on the edges of inaccessible playgrounds or been pushed out of unsustainable work cultures, the full life I live today would not exist if someone hadn't fought hard for my inclusion before I was born. I wanted Judy to

know that my outrage over the exclusion disabled people still face didn’t diminish my appreciation for the gifts she had granted us. I think I convinced her I could hold both stories as true.

Taussig at the Toronto International Film Festival on Sept. 10Arturo Holmes—Getty Images

While it didn’t make the final cut, one of the scenes performed at our table read told the story of the time Judy was forcibly removed from a plane when the airline insisted she needed a care attendant or a note from a doctor to fly. Someone expressed appreciation that

airlines are now more accommodating to wheelchair travelers. Siân looked at me knowingly. “Well, they’re still not great,” she said.

And so when I flew home from the reading, I can’t say I was surprised to find upon landing that my wheelchair, which cost more than my car and is fully customized to prevent pain and pressure sores, was missing. In its absence, I was placed in an airport wheelchair—although, given that it was not self-propelling, it feels more apt to call it a cart. Because airplanes don’t have accessible bathrooms, I hadn’t peed in eight hours, but without wheels that I could push myself, I couldn’t get to a toilet without help. I almost always fly alone, but out of sheer luck, my husband had accompanied me on this trip. We watched the people from the last flights pour out the doors until the floor was empty. Over an hour later, the airline informed us they had no idea where the wheelchair was. I felt like I was being sent home with body parts missing.

The next day, as I sat at my kitchen table, calling the same customer-service numbers again and again, a -familiar feeling thumped in my chest. While we worked on the script, I wanted to capture the frantic helplessness that can come when your basic rights are not in your control. You can hold up a protest sign, put your body on the line, hurl your voice to the sky, write yet another email to legislators, and still, it often feels like you are entirely at the mercy of a few people at the top who aren’t even listening.

Two days later, my husband found the frame of my wheelchair dropped off on our doorstep, scratches across the front, two parts dangling. They never found the wheels. A replacement pair arrived three weeks later.

While I recounted the ordeal to Siân, we marveled at the irony. Here we were, telling the story of a woman who took on the airlines for disabled passengers to have equal access to travel, and 50 years later disabled travelers still take the very real risk of our lives being upended every time we fly. We have come so far. We

have so far to go. I saw the dichotomy everywhere. It was my generation's job, I thought, to build on the progress Judy's had fought for. What I didn't realize at the time, however, is that we wouldn't just be advancing it—we'd be defending it as well.

Almost a year to the date of that hopeful, disastrous flight home, I found out that Apple Studios had greenlighted the making of *Being Heumann.* I texted Siân gleeful curse words in disbelief. In the coming months, I saw a big film studio prioritize authentic disability casting for more roles than I could count on my hands and ask good questions about how to make the filming process accessible for them. I think I stopped breathing while I watched Ruth Madeley channel Judy's chutzpah on her audition tape. Every time I thought of my younger self getting the chance to watch this story with these characters, my eyes welled. There is no way to quantify what it would have meant to see bodies like mine do something as ordinary as get dressed, go to work, or receive care, let alone hook up, party, fight, cry and win together. To see the world reflected back to me as I experienced it—pushed out by stairs and curbs, racing wheelchairs down hallways, sitting eye level with butts.

'Being Heumann' tells the story of how a group of protesters, including Heumann, fought for the implementation of Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, a federal civil rights lawApple

It was right in the middle of this dreamy bubble that I first learned about a new lawsuit, *Texas v. Becerra*, filed by the attorneys general in 17 states, seeking to make Section 504 unconstitutional or dismantle all of the detailed protections that it lays out. I scoured the internet for any reporting from mainstream news outlets. The silence stunned me. I went directly to the lawsuit itself, and as I squinted into the legalese, I recognized arguments that sounded identical to the ones posed in the 1970s. We'd written these sentiments into the mouths of our most skeptical characters: *disabled people are a burden on the rest of us; we shouldn't be forced to integrate them into our communities.*

Over the course of two years, the lawsuit evolved; it was updated as *Texas v. Kennedy*, the people made noise, and many states dropped out. Then in June, the Justice Department's Office of Legal Counsel issued a memo asserting that Section 504 and the ADA don't actually mandate that states support disabled people to remain integrated in their communities. Instead, this memo claims, sending people to live in institutions—away from their families, friends, and beds—is an acceptable option. This position is in direct conflict with the way disability-rights law has been interpreted by courts for decades. And, in addition to the human cost, it doesn't make fiscal sense. For example, according to the Kansas Department for Aging and Disability Services and the Disability Rights Center of Kansas, sending one person with an intellectual or developmental disability (I/DD) to live in an institution can easily cost well over $310,000 a year. Providing home- and community-based services with an I/DD waiver for this same person would cost, on average, $70,000 a year. The discrepancy is similarly steep for someone with a physical disability. So at least in this case, it costs less to include us.

Even so, that memo set the foundation for a joint proposal from the Department of Justice and the five remaining states that ultimately ended the case. They asked the court to vacate critical language about integration, and in September the judge agreed. Now the law

remains on the books—only Congress can change the legislation itself—but it's been utterly gutted, despite the loud outcry from disability advocates across the country and the way it had been applied since the protesters won their fight in 1977. It's hard not to interpret this move as anything other than a profound disregard for the value of disabled life.

And yet, even as the lawsuit and memo wound their way through the government, the Toronto International Film Festival welcomed *Being Heumann* as its opening-night film. I rolled across the red carpet in my black sequined dress and scratched-up wheelchair frame, taking in the wide expanse of our embodied disabilities, each of us glammed out and feted for our talents. It felt like living inside two timelines: one where my government undercuts the foundations of laws that have long protected all of us, the other where the hubs of culture celebrate the incredible story behind the passing of those same laws. As Judy's life's work is threatened, audiences around the world are learning her name. The past is asserting itself into the present, the future is teetering toward the past, all inside one surreal moment. I'm trying to hold onto the contradiction, never allowing the significance of one reality to eclipse the other.

I wish Judy were here to give us our marching orders—to make the monster lurking around the corner feel a little smaller with the force of her voice. I wish she could take in the wild power of her own story moving across a screen and witness this outpouring of recognition, gratitude, and celebration. She died unexpectedly while we were working on the film. In fact, many of the 504 leaders have passed away—Brad Lomax, Ed Roberts, Kitty Cone, Ron Washington, Hale Zukas. Their generation came of age in a world where doctors routinely told parents they should send their disabled children away to live out their lives in institutions, but their activism fundamentally changed the lives of all of us coming

up behind them. Now that we are the adults in the room, what legacy will we leave behind?

I find myself thinking a lot about the work culture can do where legislation drops off. As we continue to fight for the laws Judy and her peers helped make real, I wonder about the ripples of an entertaining movie that isn't here to force a lesson but bring to life a vivid story of disability as a dynamic, nuanced, deeply human experience. I wonder if one film might beget more. Perhaps this kind of authentic representation of disabled life could be a fixture that younger generations will one day take for granted. Maybe storytelling can insist on our shared humanity in the ways legislation can't.

Because, even as I see now more than ever how essential laws can be, I don't want just laws; I also want a society that values disabled people enough to implement them meaningfully and fully. I want whole communities invested in the great, ongoing project of building a world for all of us. I think Judy would co-sign my enormous appetite. I no longer believe human evolution inevitably bends toward including more of us, but if she taught us anything, it's that we don't show up because the outcome is guaranteed; we show up because it isn't.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/28/being-heumann-movie-essay/

Entertainment | movies

John Malkovich and Sam Rockwell Are Pure Delight in Martin McDonagh's *Wild Horse Nine*

Malkovich as Chris and Rockwell as Lee in Wild Horse NineCourtesy of Searchlight Pictures

Where's the line between shtick and style? If a filmmaker returns to similar themes over and over again but folds them into entertaining shapes each time, is that consistency or a lack of imagination? Writer-director Martin McDonagh's *Wild Horse Nine*—playing in competition here at the Venice Film Festival—might prompt you to ask those questions, though it doesn't fully answer them. Like *In Bruges* and *The Banshees of Inisherin*, *Wild Horse Nine*—in which John Malkovich and Sam Rockwell play 1970s CIA agents stationed in Santiago, Chile, sent to Easter Island on a special mission—deals with fractious male friendships. There are some beautiful four-legged animals—in this case, horses—but one of them must die; it's as if McDonagh feels he needs to toughen us up to the realities of nature, rather than just allow us to enjoy an animal's spirit and beauty. And there are ways in which McDonagh gets tripped up by his own excessive cleverness: the screenplay is

so packed with quirky quips that you might long for a little breathing room.

But if the writing sometimes comes off as winking and belabored, the acting is not. Malkovich and Rockwell are a joy to watch, and that, after all, is what we continue to go to the movies for: to see actors at play, even as they work. Malkovich's Chris and Rockwell's Lee are an odd-couple duo who have been working together long enough to intuit one another's thoughts and moods. They also bicker, a lot. Lee seems annoyed by his elder partner's tendency to tootle down trails of fanciful thought. In an early scene, Chris complains that his apartment in Santiago is riddled with moths, and he doesn't want them to ruin his clothes. But he also doesn't want to kill them. Instead, he says, "I've been escorting them outside." It's 1973, not long before socialist president Salvador Allende will be overthrown in a military coup—Chris and Lee know that's going to happen, given that their job is to destabilize democratic governments here and there around the world. In one of his many pensive moments, Chris muses, "Sometimes I think I care about the moths in Chile more than I care about the people in Chile."

Malkovich as Chris with "the big heads" he's always wanted to seeCourtesy of Searchlight Pictures

Yet somehow Chris *does* care, despite having secretively killed some 68 people in his long career, and possibly, as one of the movie's running gags suggests, having had a hand in some grassy-knoll shenanigans in November 1963. He falls asleep listening to one of the saddest ballads ever written, Hank Williams' "I'm So Lonesome I Could Cry." He not-so-secretly hates his boss, MJ (a delightfully ruthless Steve Buscemi) and joyfully spreads lies—or are they?—that he's a junkie. But Chris himself does heroin, not for pleasure, but because cancer is killing him. He's happy to have been dispatched to Easter Island—he has long wanted to see what he calls "the big heads"—and he claims that he's going to get some work done on his long-planned memoir. Lee reminds him that his memory is like a sieve; Chris asserts that working on the memoir will bring it back. He wants his book to begin with a surprise opening, not a boring one, so he decides he's going to open by talking about dinosaurs. "Did they have souls?" he wonders aloud. Lee scoffs at this idea, but by this point, we've already seen the affection, mingled with annoyance, between these men. Chris considers Lee his only friend.

That basic framework sets the stage for lots of acerbic CIA jokes, some flirtation with a duo of pretty student tourists (played by Ailín Salas and Mariana Di Girólamo), and a truly fantastic gag about how the "gay" countries produce the best cheeses. (Chris' definition of what makes a country gay or not is far from sound, but even so, he may be onto something.) Chris delights in the wild horses that roam Easter Island, forming a kind of soul communion with one in particular, a striking, sensitive beast who nods his head perceptively whenever Chris asks him a question. McDonagh never wants our emotions to get too squishy—remember the donkey in *The Banshees of Inisherin*?—and thus this noble creature meets an unexplained, albeit gentle, end. But there's still a degree of warmth here, perhaps more so than in most of McDonagh's films. This one, at least, has none of the smug superiority of *Three Billboards*

Outside Ebbing, Missouri, a film ringing with condescension toward small-town America.

McDonagh may often be excessively arch, but he does know how to write for actors. Rockwell's Lee is essentially the straight man here, absorbing the vibrations of his friend and colleague's meandering thoughts on mortality and other subjects. That doesn't make it a minor role; Lee is Chris' mirror and sounding board, the trustworthy compatriot who both protects his friend and gives it to him straight. This is a generous performance, one that favors listening over mere line delivery. And Malkovich is simply wonderful. Chris, nearing not just the end of his CIA career but his life, has blown out his filter; now he just blurts the truth. When one of the young, earnestly leftist tourists speaks, with sparkling eyes, about the power of organized protests, Chris gives it to her straight: "Marches are just the places we can get the clearest photos of you without your knowing." Malkovich doesn't make the line sound cruel or demeaning. He launches it with a kind of bounce, the way you'd serve a tennis ball. He's having fun here, and his pleasure becomes our delight. He makes you believe in a guy who would send an invasive, wool-munching insect out into the night air without crushing it. No one can deliver a moth soliloquy like he can.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/03/wild-horse-nine-review/

Entertainment | movies

Lee Chang Dong's *Possible Love* Is a Delicate Drama of Love and Longing in Anxious Times

(L to R) Sul Kyung-gu as Ho-seok, Jeon Do-yeon as Mi-ok, Cho Yeo-jeong as Ye-ji, Zo In-sung as Sang-woo in Possible LoveCourtesy of Netflix

Lee Chang-dong's delicate yet sturdy drama *Possible Love*—premiering here at the Venice Film Festival, hitting theaters Oct. 23 and streaming on Netflix Nov. 6—is a movie about figuring out how to function in the world. If that description seems confoundingly vague, Lee's movie is not. It shows us a world where people feel lost after losing their livelihood, where individuals strive to connect with others despite differences of class and temperament, where tenderness ultimately has more power than arrogance. It's a movie with a gentle, generous spirit.

Lee opens the picture with a funeral, or, rather, a small family piling into their car to get to the funeral venue. Wife and mother Mi-ok (Jeon Do-yeon) wonders if she's wearing the right dress, and the shoes she has chosen, a pair she hasn't worn in a long time, are already pinching her feet. Her husband, Ho-seok (Sul Kyung-gu),

says little—so little that it's clear he's filled with dread over whatever awaits him at this upcoming, obviously unhappy social event. Their extremely quiet young son (Jung Seop) sits in the back seat, amusing himself by dangling an empty chip bag out the window like a windsock. "It's flying," he says, just before letting it go—he's not the only one feeling the oppressiveness of that car ride.

It's never expressly spelled out who this funeral is for, but we can intuit that it's one of Ho-seok's former work colleagues. It turns out that Ho-seok is one of many workers who not so long ago lost his job at a large corporation, SP, and he hasn't yet recovered, either financially or emotionally. Mi-ok is doing the best she can—she holds down a menial factory job—but her husband's depression and excessive drinking is getting to her. By chance, in the funeral home parking lot, she meets a handsome stranger, Sang-woo (Zo In-sung), who moves his very expensive car when Mi-ok believes her wedding ring, having slipped off her finger, has rolled beneath it. It turns out that Sang-woo's wife, Ye-ji (Cho Yeo-Jong), is making a documentary about, as she puts it, "the personal lives of laborers." Ye-ji is thrilled to have found Mi-ok and Ho-seok as subjects—she's particularly interested in the melancholic Ho-seok, who, she believes, could be the dramatic key her project. But she and Mi-ok also genuinely like each other and strike up a friendship. *Possible Love* traces the tangled dynamics between these four characters, while also flirting with uncomfortable questions about the moral quandaries that can arise in any filmmaker-subject relationship.

Zo In-sung as Sang-woo, Jeon Do-yeon as Mi-okCourtesy of Netflix

Mostly, though, *Possible Love* traces the ways people come to care for one another, either platonically or romantically. Ye-ji and Mi-ok quickly come to think of themselves as sisters. Though Ye-ji has married well, she doesn't come from a privileged family—her father ran a dry-cleaning establishment—and she has some sense of Mi-ok's money worries and feelings of insecurity. At an early meeting, where Ye-ji outlines the aim of her proposed documentary to Mi-ok, she leaves the table momentarily, and Mi-ok snaps a picture of the elegant backpack she's left behind. Then she uses a Google-image search to find out the brand. It's made by Loro Piana, and quite obviously beyond Mi-ok's means. That's just one example of how Lee explores simple human wants, desires, jealousies. We often can't help wanting things we can't afford, especially when they've already been stamped by the approval of someone we admire.

Lee has dedicated the film to the memory of Krzysztof Kieślowski's *Dekalog 10;* he has said he was particularly struck by the commandment "Thou shalt not covet." As humans, we often like nice things, but what we really need is a way to keep a roof over our head and food on the table. *Possible Love* explores the desperation that can strike when we can't meet those basic needs. Sang-woo, cocksure and a little clueless, spends much of the movie

on the phone making business deals. Meanwhile, Ho-seok suffers quietly, as if encased in a bubble of isolation. Mi-ok loves him, but she's frustrated with him; no wonder she's drawn, perhaps romantically, to sexy and stalwart Sang-woo. The movie's most potent scene occurs late in the film when, with Ye-ji's camera rolling, Ho-seok finally lets his guard down: Ye-ji may be getting the footage she set out for, but has she earned it honestly? Sul Kyung-gu is sensational here. If the character he's playing is key to Ye-ji's movie-within-a-movie, he's also *Possible Love*'s anguished beating heart.

Lee's 2018 noir mystery *Burning* was, what we used to call in the days before the pandemic, a surprise art-house hit. An art-house hit today may not mean the same thing as it did then, given how much the cinema-going audience has shrunk in less than 10 years. It's hard to predict whether *Possible Love* will find a similarly enthusiastic audience. This is perhaps a more plainspoken movie than *Burning*; its moral questions are fairly easy to identify and parse. But at a time when more people worldwide are worrying about hanging onto gainful employment, even as a relatively small handful of people control the majority of the world's wealth, the dramatic pull of *Possible Love* may be even greater than that of *Burning.* Sometimes it's a relief when a movie captures undercurrents of anxiety that, in our daily lives, we find difficult to put into words. With *Possible Love*, it's as if Lee has taken our unspoken feelings and handed them to his actors. With words and gestures, with tentative smiles and flashes of anger, they show us fears and worries we might be feeling ourselves, possibly galvanizing us to face them.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/02/possible-love-review-lee-chang-dong/

Entertainment | Television

Nocturne Is a Slow-Burning Crime Drama That Struggles to Stay Lit

Stephen Graham, left, and Liev Schreiber in NocturneApple TV

00:0005:12

Narrated by TIME AI.

Nocturne is everything you would expect from a 21st century prestige crime drama. Adapted from a series of best-selling Scandinavian mystery novels, the Apple TV thriller, premiering with two episodes on Oct. 30, casts a genuine movie star (Liev Schreiber) as a brilliant yet broken detective immersed in a case that has become an all-consuming obsession. The large ensemble represents multiple law-enforcement agencies, victims, bystanders, and a singular alleged serial killer played by an actor on a hot streak (Stephen Graham). Children's lives are at stake. A risky undercover operation is undertaken. Relationships simmer, until suddenly they're at a full boil. Collateral damage piles up. Progress is glacial, with essential bits of backstory meted out in stingy

flashbacks. Underlying every scene is an atmosphere heavy with dread, as though this sordid scenario has arisen not merely from the brain of one twisted villain, but out of a rot at the heart of society.

It's a prototypical slow burn. This format, in which one complex investigation spans a season or more, wasn't new to American TV when AMC's Nordic noir adaptation *The Killing* became a sensation in 2011. (In this respect and many others, *Twin Peaks*, for one, was ahead of its time.) But the convergence of streaming, an ideal venue for binge-friendly serialized storytelling, and an audience for ambitious television that had been growing for more than a decade facilitated its proliferation as a cinematic alternative to the formulaic procedurals that still predominate on broadcast networks. The most acclaimed and discussed mystery shows of the past 15 years—*True Detective*, *Mare of Easttown*, *Fargo*, even *Only Murders in the Building*—have been, with few exceptions, slow burns. Yet, as *Nocturne*'s mixed success suggests, the tropes and limitations of the style become more apparent with each new title.

Zazie Beetz in NocturneApple TV

In one welcome deviation from the norm, whodunit seems clear from the beginning. Confined in the bowels of a Pennsylvania psychiatric hospital, the serial killer Jurek Walter (Graham) calmly

coaxes an inmate in the adjacent solitary cell into suicide. When a boy thought to be one of his victims, Michael (Landon Valentin), turns up, filthy and feeble but alive, years after he and his sister went missing, a new hunt for the girl begins. Schreiber's Jonah Lynn, a Philly cop and military veteran who is now retired and a bit reclusive, was instrumental in the original investigation. Michael's return draws him back in, along with an FBI agent, Saga (Zazie Beetz), who is a surrogate daughter to Jonah. As Quinn, a rigorous colleague from the bureau (Poorna Jagannathan), and the weary local police chief (Bill Camp) lead the search, Saga goes undercover as a patient at the hospital and Jonah goes rogue, to the surprise of no one who has ever worked with him. They don't just want to find the sister; they want to catch Jurek masterminding violent crimes from his cell, thereby proving he's coherent enough to rot in a real prison.

A slow burn can only be as compelling as the personalities and ideas its pace affords it time to explore. Creator Rowan Joffé and his cast, adapting the Joona Linna novels by Lars Kepler (a pen name of Swedish husband-andwife team Alexander Ahndoril and Alexandra Coelho Ahndoril), do craft a few fascinating characters. Beetz's Saga is a spookily canny mix of actor, detective, and daredevil, inhabiting her cutesy-until-she's-not patient persona so fully, you might start to doubt she's fully faking it. Graham weaponizes the soft masculinity that he wielded so movingly as the horrified father of a homicidal teen incel in *Adolescence*. It's his cunning performances of compassion that set Jurek apart from the typical thriller psycho and make us believe he has the capacity to pull off logistically inconceivable feats of cruelty. Rory Culkin adds tension as Karl, a sensitive hospital worker whose anger at the way superiors use him as a pawn leaves him vulnerable to Jurek's manipulation.

From left: Poorna Jagannathan, Stephen Graham, and Liev Schreiber in NocturneApple TV

What happens outside the institution isn't nearly as gripping. Strong actors like Camp, Jagannathan, and Chrissy Metz, who plays Michael's mother Ida, are saddled with underwritten characters. Everything we know about Jonah—that he's brooding, single-minded, and willing to break rules in pursuit of justice—is a cliché of the genre, as is his odd-couple partnership with the stiff but well-intentioned Quinn. I got the sense, around the season's midpoint (seven out of 10 episodes were provided for review), that Joffé was holding some of these characters at arm's length in order to shock us with revelations about them later. But the extended delay in supplying basic context about Jonah, in particular, comes off as too much of a contrivance. It also distances us from the show's implicit questions about whether laws and protocols enable (or prevent) justice, and how people like Jonah and Saga should weigh the rewards of dangerous, personal missions against the threat of harm these crusades pose.

Nocturne's small-town Pennsylvania setting is guaranteed to earn it comparisons to *Mare of Easttown* and its spiritual sequel, *Task*. Beyond the dutifully adopted (and, to my ears, pretty accurate) accents, though, it lacks the specificity of those shows, both created by area native Brad Ingelsby, with regard to the region and its people. It doesn't have the same curiosity about or patience in depicting the characters' lives outside the Jurek case, either. Viewers got invested in Kate Winslet's Mare because we got to watch her try to keep up with her precocious teenage daughter and

endure the harsh words of her judgmental mom. (It didn’t hurt that said mom was played by Jean Smart.) As Robbie in *Task*, Tom Pelphrey had space to show us a criminal who was also a lonely, newly single father desperate to provide for his beloved children.

As any connoisseur of the hundreds of crime serials TV has produced since *The Killing* can tell you, there are only so many murder plots. But there are as many unique characters as there are human beings on planet earth. A slow burn that doesn’t make use of such a rich source of fuel is apt to fizzle out.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/27/nocturne-review-apple/

Entertainment | Television

The One About Matthew Perry Is More Than the Typical Saga of Fame and Addiction

The One About Matthew PerryNetflix

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Narrated by TIME AI.

When it comes to representing the famous and addicted, Hollywood seems to know only two stories. Both begin with a passionate talent who longs to make an impact on the world. Then, as no less an expert on this subject than Courtney Love memorably put it, they get what they want and they never want it again. Afflicted by affluenza or impostor syndrome or the newfound knowledge that success can’t heal their internal wounds, they escape into substance abuse. It’s only in their final chapters that the two narratives diverge. Some lucky souls hit rock bottom, get clean, and live happily ever after. The rest die young.

It would be easy to slot Matthew Perry, the *Friends* star who died from ketamine and drowning in October 2023, into the latter category. But in the intimate three-part Netflix documentary *The One About Matthew Perry*, director Mary Robertson (*Quiet on the Set: The Dark Side of Kids TV*) honors his memory by resisting that simplistic binary. Yes, addiction (and a cadre of enablers who are now serving time for their roles in his death) killed Perry at 54. It's also true that he spent more than 25 years surviving it, fighting to act and write and enjoy his friendships and make his family proud and fall in love. Instead of hiding that struggle, he used his fortune to aid others in their recoveries and his platform to advocate for a broader understanding of addiction as the illness that it is.

Robertson captures all of this in straightforward, chronological order, through emotional interviews with family and longtime friends, as well as Perry's own startlingly frank reflections in media appearances and his 2022 memoir, *Friends, Lovers, and the Big Terrible Thing*. The absence of major celebrities, whether by design or otherwise, limits the fond platitudes. In their place are vivid behind-the-scenes anecdotes and candid memories of who he was offscreen—the ambition, charm, humor, and magnanimity, but also the pain he was capable of inflicting on those who loved and needed him. His sister Mia Perry Bowick, a psychotherapist, is the most insightful presence, embracing grief and ambivalence as she ties her big brother's highs and lows to early family dynamics.

With all due respect to Chandler Bing, Perry's greatest contribution was his vulnerability, even when the image of him it exposed wasn't flattering. In its honesty, this documentary continues that work.

Correction, Oct. 27

The original version of this story misstated the last name of the series' director. She is Mary Robertson, not Mary Robinson.

https://time.com/article/2026/10/27/the-one-about-matthew-perry-review/

Entertainment | movies

John Turturro Will Pick Your Pocket and Steal Your Heart

John Turturro at the Toronto International Film Festival on Sept. 14, 2026Gareth Cattermole—Getty Images for IMDb

00:0008:29

Narrated by TIME AI.

If it seems like no one else could play the role John Turturro plays in *The Only Living Pickpocket in New York*, you can imagine the angst writer-director Noah Segan felt when he sent the screenplay to the actor hoping for a “yes.” Turturro brings world-weariness, tenderness, and New York City street smarts to his turn as Harry, a career criminal whose way of life is disappearing in a cashless, electronic, often colder world. The character may steal to put food on his table, but he’s also loyal and honest in his own way, caring for a permanently disabled wife and practically a saint when compared with the tech-enabled, mafia nepo baby (Will Price) he

makes the mistake of stealing from, setting off the movie's drama and putting his life in jeopardy.

Turturro, who has been a ubiquitous presence in film, TV, and theater for decades, truly seems to be everywhere these days—in an acclaimed production heading for Broadway, in *Severance*, whose fans eagerly await a third season, in the forthcoming climate-change dramedy *A Statement* from *Spotlight* director Tom McCarthy, and of course anywhere the Knicks are. With *Pickpocket*, he could very well land his first Oscar nomination in a career full of performances that have certainly qualified for consideration, from *Barton Fink* to *Quiz Show* to more Spike Lee films than any other actor has appeared in.

Ahead of the theatrical release of *The Only Living Pickpocket in New York*, which hit theaters nationwide on Oct. 30, Turturro spoke to TIME about how his hometown has changed, his love for collaborators old and new, and his nerves heading into this year's NBA season.

Read more: John Turturro Gives a Career-Best Performance in *The Only Living Pickpocket in New York*

Giancarlo Esposito and John Turturro in The Only Living Pickpocket in New YorkCourtesy of Sony Pictures Classics

Noah Segan said that when he came to meet you, “We had some soup and fell in love.” Did you need to be convinced to take the part?

I read so many scripts, and so many of them are derivative. Sometimes they're just violent for violence's sake. Someone's seen you do something, and they say, "Well, he could do this.” I said, "Is this as good as I think it is?” I was struck by the structure of it, because I love Greek plays. I love that Aristotelian 24-hour time frame, when something has tension and propulsive movement, an odyssey to survive in a short time, and then it's juxtaposed with this tenderness and the specificity of language. I met Noah, and I liked him. He's a gentle guy, but he has a backbone. When Noah gave me the script, it's like a gift. You want to reciprocate. You want to surprise that person.

Harry is a criminal, but he operates by a code. He’s true to his word. He’s loyal to his wife. Do you see him as an antihero?

I just try to play a person. I’ve read about a lot of these guys. They were from broken homes, orphanages. They didn’t have a family, so they formed this little family with other people who didn’t want to hurt people. Even though it is a violation, it was nonviolent. It was like a magic trick. They’re taking something. But there’s a lot of people who pick our pockets every day. And they take our world sometimes.

The movie has a real nostalgia for the old New York, a more analog time. Do you share that feeling?

Everything changes. You walk down Bleecker Street, all these theaters, nightclubs are gone. It’s CVS. Ethnic neighborhoods aren’t there anymore. It takes away from the texture of a neighborhood. The thing I miss is things being affordable. When I was young, even if I sat in the back, I could see anyone. Jimi Hendrix at the Electric Circus. Colleen Dewhurst or George C. Scott. I got an education that way, while I was getting a [formal] education, and it opened up my horizons of thinking someday I could make a living doing this.

The city also feels different from decades past because we’re all staring down at our phones instead of looking at each other as we walk down the street.

There's so many people. We're all going somewhere. And there's plenty of people that aren't there. There's a lot of people gone now from all different generations, and you're more and more surrounded by ghosts. In my phone, I don't take people out because maybe I need the number in the afterlife or something. You just understand that there is a clock to our lives, and what you give is also important. It's not just what you take, and I believe in that.

The movie was filmed in every borough, right? It doesn’t feel like a gimmick, but something that could plausibly happen in this character’s life.

The guy is sort of a superhero. He knows the transit lines, the buses, the subways. He doesn't take Ubers. I take subways and I walk everywhere. I love it when I go to an event and everyone's sharing that on the train. It’s kind of about the underbelly, the people keep the city humming. Even though this is not a film about the working class, it is, sort of. The elevator doesn't work. The heat

isn't so great. These are real problems, and those people sometimes are not explored as much.

There’s a wonderful scene where Harry dances to the song “Native New Yorker” for his wife Rosie, who is disabled and non-verbal. Was that improvised?

I like to dance. I studied dance. In my household, everybody was dancing, three boys, my mom was a great dancer. I used to go out dancing to that song. When people are incapacitated, you play music, you sing, you dance. It’s a love scene. Movement, especially when it’s not overly choreographed, brings joy. Even in intense stories, people stop to do things. They stop to eat. They stop to have a laugh.

You go way back with two of your co-stars, Giancarlo Esposito, who plays a detective who’s almost like a colleague of Harry’s, and Steve Buscemi, who owns the pawn shop where he brings his stolen wares. How did that come about? Did you suggest them?

Yeah, we talked about it, and I asked Giancarlo to read it. And Steve and I know each other. We've been neighbors. He's a beautiful guy. He's a beautiful actor. We have a history there, so it's not like we have to invent that. So that was helpful in the movie.

You and Tatiana Maslany, who’s also in this film, just finished the play *Rhinoceros* together. Do you

like to get back to the theater every once in a while to sort of sharpen the tools?

That's where I come from. I love the rehearsal process, if it's a very open one, which we did in *Rhinoceros* with [director] Diane Paulus. We explored everything. It's exhausting, I don't want to do a run for half a year. But I love doing things that young people can come to and afford. It's real teamwork, and I think it's kept me fresh for doing film work. It's humbling, and it's nerve-racking, and it's also exhilarating when you're able to keep your balance.

There's so much love for your character Irving on *Severance*. And fans really obsess over this show with conspiracy theories. Have you been a part of something like that before?

I love Irving too. I have enjoyed working with the entire group, and especially with the apple of my eye, Chris [Walken]. *Severance* poses questions of work life, personal life. Maybe it resonates in the world. Maybe even more now with all this AI stuff. I think one of the strengths of the show is that it poses these questions and doesn't answer them. When you answer it, it's not as satisfying as figuring it out.

As a prominent Knicks fan, how are you feeling about this season?

I feel hopeful. I'm not overconfident. It was beautiful how they all coalesced. I treasure being a fan and a season-ticket holder. I'm still soaking it all in. My favorite thing was coming home on the train, everyone just being in shock. It's great when people come together.

Correction, Oct. 30

The original version of this story misstated which season of *Severance* is forthcoming. It will be the third season, not the fourth.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/30/john-turturro-interview-only-living-pickpocket-in-new-york/

Health

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Health | Cancer

What to Know About Pope Leo's Lung Cancer Diagnosis

Pope Leo during a trip to Madrid on June 7, 2026.Dan Kitwood—Getty Images

After discovering a nodule in Pope Leo XIV's lung, surgeons at Gemelli Hospital in Rome performed surgery on Tuesday that revealed the Pope has cancer.

Dr. Stefano Margaritora, professor of thoracic surgery at the Catholic University of Sacred Heart, led the team that operated on the Pope at Gemelli, which has long provided care for Popes. The surgery was prompted after the Pope’s medical team, led by Dr. Luigi Carbone, found a suspicious nodule and performed tests that suggested it could be cancerous, according to a statement released by the Vatican. During the 90-minute operation, Margaritora removed the lower lobe of the Pope’s right lung, and further testing of the tissue confirmed adenocarcinoma.

What is lung adenocarcinoma?

Lung adenocarcinoma is the most common type of lung cancer worldwide, accounting for 40% to 45% of lung cancer cases globally. Adenocarcinomas belong to a broader category of lung cancers known as non-small cell lung cancer, which tend to grow more slowly and spread less quickly to other parts of the body. Detecting adenocarcinomas early can help keep them from progressing to advanced disease.

How is lung cancer detected?

Current recommendations in the U.S. and most of the world advise low-dose CT scans to screen for lung cancer in high-risk people only: those 50 years or older who have smoked heavily in the past or who currently smoke. Many non-smokers are diagnosed with lung cancer when they get a chest CT for another reason, such as after an accident or other injury. Some advocacy and patient groups are pushing for expanded screening among those at higher risk so that more people can benefit from early detection, including those who are younger and may have been exposed to other factors that can increase lung cancer risk, like radon in the environment. “The best chance to cure lung cancer is when it’s Stage 1 and very early,” says Dr. David Jones, chief or thoracic surgery at Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center, who was not involved in the Pope’s care. “That’s what screening can help with.”

The Pope's smoking history is not publicly known, but lung adenocarcinoma occurs in both smokers and non-smokers, says Jones. “Lung adenocarcinoma is by far the most common type of lung cancer in non-smokers,” he says.

Why did surgeons remove part of the Pope's lung?

Surgeons decided to remove part of the Pope's lung "to ensure a radical resection," according to the Vatican statement. That means doctors wanted to be sure they removed any tissue that might be cancerous, giving the Pope the strongest chance of avoiding any recurrence of disease.

How long will the Pope be hospitalized?

The Pope woke up from surgical anesthesia without any complications, and requested dinner while conversing with Vatican staff. He will be observed as additional tests are performed on his removed cancer tissue to guide doctors on what treatments might be needed next. The Vatican anticipates the Pope will remain at Gemelli for one week.

What are the treatments for lung adenocarcinoma?

The Pope's treatment options depend on what additional tests on his tumor reveal. For some patients with Stage 1 cancer that has not spread to the lymph nodes, surgery and monitoring for recurrence may be sufficient, says Jones.

If the cancer is more advanced, a number of relatively new options for lung cancer are available, including targeted therapies designed to specifically attack certain mutations in cancer cells, or immunotherapy, which activates the immune system into destroying cancer cells. "The innovation in treatments for lung cancer have been profound," says Karen Knudsen, CEO of the Parker Institute. Adenocarcinomas tend to have high numbers of mutations, which make them good targets for the immune system to recognize as foreign. That also makes them promising targets for

checkpoint inhibitors, a new category of cancer therapy that releases the brakes on immune cells and allows them to better detect and destroy cancer cells. “Our knowledge base is improving, and there are better outcomes for non-small cell lung cancer because of immunotherapy,” says Knudsen.

Some patients can rely on targeted therapies alone and avoid chemotherapy, says Jones, while others may need chemo with immunotherapy, depending on how much of the cancer surgeons were able to remove and whether the cancer had spread to the lymph nodes.

Will Pope Leo be able to resume his papal duties?

The Vatican reports that prior to the surgery, the Pope was active, playing tennis and taking regular walks, and with the range of treatment options now available to treat his cancer, experts believe he should be able to return to his daily activities. “Advances in treatments all point to better prognosis and quality of life for patients with lung cancer,” says Jones. “And given his history of physical activity, even after removing one lobe of his lung, he should be able to do what he wants to do with very little limitation.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/14/pope-leo-lung-cancer-what-to-know/

Health | Drugs

Compounding Pharmacies for Weight-Loss Drugs Are Booming. Should You Trust Them?

Mr. Ilkin—Getty Images

Before the pandemic, Diane Kinkade lost weight with diet and exercise. But by 2026, she decided she needed to try something else. She had prediabetes and high blood pressure, in addition to being overweight, but her doctor declined to prescribe her a GLP-1 weight-loss medication, saying he thought the side effects outweighed the benefits. So she asked around and found a telehealth site that seemed more than happy to send her a prescription for a GLP-1 after a brief questionnaire.

But the telehealth site didn't send her a brand-name drug. It instead partnered with a compounding pharmacy to send her tirzepatide, the active ingredient in Eli Lilly's popular drug Zepbound. The compounded drug represented significant cost savings—$250 a month versus the $399 a month she would have paid through LillyDirect, the direct-to-consumer site that people often use when their insurance doesn't cover the drug.

Kinkade, who is 72, says she wasn't too worried about injecting herself with what the compounding pharmacy had sent, a combination of tirzepatide and vitamin B12. At first, she started to lose weight. But a few months into her injections, the telehealth site switched compounding pharmacies, and she had such bad side effects from the new medication (ordered with the same prescription) that she says she could barely function. Brain fog, nausea, diarrhea, and exhaustion all plagued her.

"I could barely get up from the couch for a week," she says. She tried reaching out to the telehealth site for help, but they just sent her canned, AI-type responses, she says. So she stopped taking the medication.

If Eli Lilly had its way, patients seeking tirzepatide would not be able to receive anything but Zepbound, which is approved by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA). The company's patent on the drug does not expire until 2036.

In a 2024 news release from Eli Lilly about litigation it had pursued against compounding pharmacies, the company says that it is "the only lawful supplier of FDA-approved tirzepatide medicines in the United States" and that "patients taking a product referred to only as 'tirzepatide' are not taking an FDA-approved product."

But because of a loophole—or a lack of enforcement, depending on who you ask—compounding pharmacies have still been sending patients compounded versions of tirzepatide.

An estimated 5 million people are using compounded GLP-1s in the U.S., according to a Gallup poll released in July; of the 11% of U.S. adults taking GLP-1 medications for weight loss, nearly one in five uses compounding pharmacies.

Compounding pharmacies are set to boom even further because people may soon use them to get more peptides—short chains of

amino acids that have become popular among influencers who tout their benefits (absent robust scientific evidence, in most cases) for a wide variety of ailments—than they previously could. In July, an FDA committee decided that compounding pharmacies should be allowed to prepare six peptides for consumers; the FDA has not yet decided whether it will adopt the recommendations.

But compounding pharmacies are much less regulated than the drug manufacturers that make brand-name drugs. As more telehealth sites prescribe these medications and pitch them as a way to lose weight while saving money, some patient advocates argue that more people like Kinkade will fall through the cracks of a broken regulatory system.

What are compounding pharmacies?

Many pharmacies can compound medications. Compounding involves preparing a customized medication for a specific patient's needs.

"Compounding is absolutely essential," says Dr. Anjali Deshmukh, a pediatrician and law professor at Seton Hall University. Deshmukh uses compounding pharmacies when, for example, she treats a 3-year-old with a serious disease who can't swallow tablets and needs medication in a different form.

For much of U.S. history, pharmacists had to mix individual medicines themselves: in the 1930s, three-quarters of prescriptions required in-pharmacy compounding. In this sense, compounding pharmacies have existed for as long as pharmacies have. For decades, pharmacies that compound small amounts of medication have operated under what's called Section 503A of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act. Called 503As for short, they're regulated by state boards of pharmacy.

Because they dispense small amounts of medications for individual patients, only with a doctor's prescription, most 503As aren't subject to certain FDA rules that apply to traditional larger drug manufacturers. That includes what's called "current good manufacturing practices," which are regulatory standards that ensure drugmakers record and trace every batch of product they make and have their equipment tested regularly.

They must adhere to other regulations, however. For instance, they must follow U.S. Pharmacopeia (USP) guidelines, which are set by a private non-profit that develops science-based standards for medicines, dietary supplements, and food ingredients. And they must source their active ingredients from FDA-registered suppliers, says Scott Brunner, the chief executive officer of the Alliance for Pharmacy Compounding, a trade group.

Struggles with regulation

This regulatory system has broken down before. In 2012 a compounding pharmacy called the New England Compounding Center started mass-producing medications in a setting that had been flagged as unsanitary numerous times. It shipped thousands of vials of contaminated steroid injections to patients. Dozens of people died, and investigators later found severe safety lapses in the pharmacy's production of sterile drugs. The owner of the pharmacy was later convicted of racketeering and other offenses by a federal jury.

In response, in 2013 Congress passed a law creating a new category for compounding pharmacies that serve a large number of people, which it calls outsourcing facilities. These compounding pharmacies, known as 503Bs, are more tightly controlled and closely watched; they *are* required to follow current good manufacturing practices and are subject to routine FDA inspection. Those pharmacies can compound and distribute drugs on a large

scale to help overcome national drug shortages, or when drugmakers stop making a certain drug. Unlike 503As, they can prepare batches of drugs without an individual prescription from a provider. But there are less than 100 of them in the U.S.

Both of these types of compounding pharmacies were essential when GLP-1 drugs were first released, says Brunner. Almost immediately after Zepbound, Wegovy, and Mounjaro hit the market, there were shortages. Physicians who knew that 503As could make compounded versions of the drugs with a prescription reached out to 503As to see if they could help their patients, Brunner says.

“Prescribers knew that this was a wonder drug and started sending prescriptions, saying, ‘Hey, can you make this?’” he said. “And if you were a sterile compounding pharmacy, you determined whether you could acquire the [active ingredients], and that’s how it started.”

Once the drugs were officially added to FDA shortages lists, 503Bs revamped their facilities to start mass-producing them. (It takes much longer for a 503B to ramp up because they produce large amounts of medication and must adhere to current good manufacturing practices, Brunner says.)

Seeing that compounding pharmacies were making these drugs, telehealth sites started advertising that they could provide consumers with cheap versions of GLP-1s, and patients and doctors alike became more comfortable with the idea of buying them from pharmacies they’d never visited. The initial high cost of the drugs motivated many patients to seek out cheaper versions, Brunner says.

This is not supposed to be how compounding pharmacies work, says Shabbir Safdar, executive director of the Partnership for Safe Medicines, a public-health group that aims to protect consumers

from counterfeit or unsafe medicines. In 2012, when Congress created 503Bs in response to the New England Compounding Center tragedy, it assumed that 503As would stop mass-producing drugs, he says. But "they didn't count on the 503As saying, 'Yeah, I know you did that, but I don't care. I'm going to mass produce drugs.'" (The FDA said, in a response to a query from TIME, that federal law limits when compounders can make copies of FDA-approved drugs.)

Eli Lilly has taken a position similar to Safdar's on compounding. "Everyone who needs medicine deserves real medicine that has been trialed, tested, and manufactured in compliance with the law," an Eli Lilly spokesperson wrote in a statement to TIME. Many compounding pharmacies, the spokesperson said, have been "unlawfully mass-producing knockoff drugs." The spokesperson added that "anyone selling mass compounded products—including by referring to them as 'personalized' or 'tailored'—is breaking the law and putting patient safety at risk." (Novo Nordisk did not return TIME's request for comment.)

Why compounding pharmacies are growing

The GLP-1 boom that began in 2021 was great news for compounding pharmacies. That's because at the time, many pharmacies were struggling. Consumer behavior was changing, and people were buying more of their goods and medications online. Pharmacists have long argued that middlemen called pharmacy benefit managers (PBM)—which manage prescription drug benefits for insurers—reimburse pharmacies too little for many medications, cutting into pharmacy margins.

Compounding provided a rare opportunity for many small pharmacies to turn a profit. With GLP-1s, "I don't want to compare it to a gold mine, but it's a very good revenue source for pharmacies," says Dae Lee, an attorney who focuses on pharmacy

at Buchanan Ingersoll & Rooney, a law firm. “PBM reimbursement rates are very bad, and pharmacies are losing money left and right.”

Pharmacies that submit claims for GLP-1s very often lose money by filling those prescriptions, he says, because the cost of acquiring the drugs is higher than the reimbursement they get from insurers.

With compounded GLP-1s, on the other hand, pharmacists don’t have to deal with insurance because consumers pay cash. (Because compounded drugs are not FDA-approved, insurance will largely not pay for them.)

Compounding allows pharmacies that may otherwise have to shut down to stay open, says Ilisa Bernstein, who worked at the FDA for 31 years in roles including heading human drug compounding. She is now a consultant for compounding pharmacies.

“Independent pharmacies are struggling, and they’re looking for ways to keep their doors open,” she says. “If they can meet their community's needs through compounding, they’re trying to figure it out.”

The rush in demand for peptides could provide a new revenue stream for many small pharmacies. Demand for peptides “is large and growing, and the potential volume is likely to dwarf the volumes seen with GLP-1s,” the National Association of Boards of Pharmacy wrote in its testimony for the FDA committee’s July hearing on peptides.

Can compounding pharmacies even legally sell GLP-1s?

It was easy for Kinkade to get her compounded drug. All she had to do was fill out a form with her current weight and the medications she was taking. She asked for tirzepatide and received it within a

couple of days. Some telehealth sites do sell brand-name GLP-1s, but many instead sell compounded drugs; one 2026 study in which a secret shopper easily obtained GLP-1 prescriptions from telehealth sites found that out of 45 telehealth websites, only 6 offered brand-name drugs.

Compounding pharmacies claim that the drugs they are selling are different from what the big drug companies are selling. They do this by working with medical providers to get a prescription for a different formulation of the drugs, changing the dose that they sell so that it is slightly different from what the drug manufacturer makes. The active ingredient often comes from an overseas lab. In 2025, the FDA launched a "green list" to ensure that compounding pharmacies were getting their active pharmaceutical ingredients from facilities that the agency has inspected or evaluated.

Kinkade's vial of tirzepatide, for instance, included the vitamin B12. Adding extra ingredients is one way compounding pharmacies have been trying to distinguish their product so that they're not just appearing to sell a copy of a brand-name GLP-1.

"So long as the product is not essentially a copy of a commercially available product, then compounding pharmacies can compound ingredients using semaglutide and tirzepatide," says Lee.

But what counts as "essentially a copy" is up for debate. In April 2026, the FDA clarified policies for compounders, saying that a drug is essentially a copy if it has the same active pharmaceutical ingredient as the commercially available drug product "in the same, similar, or an easily substitutable strength," or if the commercially available product can be used by the "same route of administration" (injection, for instance) prescribed for the commercially available products.

Then in September, it issued the first warning letter to a compounding pharmacy that included violations based on making

copies of FDA-approved GLP-1 drugs. “The FDA will continue taking action, where appropriate, to protect patients and consumers from illegally marketed drugs and to protect public health,” an FDA spokesperson said in a statement to TIME.

That warning letter was one of the first actions the FDA has taken on this topic, says Bernstein, the former FDA staffer. “FDA recently issued a novel warning letter that focuses on copies of GLP-1s,” she says. “The agency picks and chooses its actions—they can’t go after everything.” But, she adds, “the law was not intended for 503As to mass-produce these products in the volume that we’re seeing.”

Eli Lilly and Novo Nordisk have sued some telehealth sites for saying that they were selling name-brand drugs, but have been hesitant to sue compounding pharmacies for making copies of their drugs, says Zachary Silbersher, a patent attorney. That’s because such patent lawsuits can be extremely expensive, and it can be difficult to prove that compounders did anything wrong, especially if they have a valid prescription from a doctor. Proving patent infringement is much more difficult than most people think, he says.

“Suing individual pharmacies can take a lot more time and energy than you might realize,” he says. “The lawsuits might start costing more than they’re worth.”

Is it dangerous to buy drugs from compounding pharmacies?

Besides the deaths of a dozen people from the compounding pharmacy in New England, some groups have raised broader safety concerns about drugs from compounding pharmacies.

One research paper published in *Expert Opinion on Drug Safety* in 2025 found that people who had taken compounded GLP-1s tended

to have worse side effects—including abdominal pain, diarrhea, and nausea—than people who had used the brand-name products between 2018 and 2024. Reports of prescribing and preparation errors were also higher for compounded medications, the researchers found.

Anecdotal examples of people having bad reactions to compounded GLP-1 drugs include a woman in North Carolina who says she was hospitalized for three days after being prescribed too high a dose of a compounded GLP-1, according to an investigation by *KFF Health News*, and a Kentucky woman who wrote in the *Washington Post* about needing a liver transplant after taking a compounded GLP-1 drug mixed with vitamin B12.

“I’m actually a little appalled that we’re very comfortable injecting ourselves with these substances,” says Safdar, whose group Partnership for Safe Medicines helped fund the 2025 study. “I don’t know when we crossed the Rubicon.”

Safdar argues that there’s no way to know if the GLP-1s from compounding pharmacies are safe because they are not getting the drug from an FDA-inspected manufacturer. (They are, however, supposed to be getting the active ingredient from an FDA-approved supplier.) And while manufacturers like Eli Lilly or Novo Nordisk have to follow current good manufacturing practices, he reiterates, compounding pharmacies don’t.

“When Lilly or Novo went to the FDA and got an approval for its drug, it was for an approval of the drug that included a quality control manufacturing process,” he says. “So if you’re a compounder and you’re saying it’s the same active ingredient—well, that’s just not true.”

Brunner says that the blanket statement that compounded drugs are less safe is “subjective and unprovable.”

And many compounding pharmacies take extra steps to ensure that the active ingredients they are using are safe. Lawrence Rossetti, the CEO of Drug Crafters, a 503A in Texas, says that in addition to sourcing active pharmaceutical ingredients from FDA-registered suppliers, Drug Crafters tests the raw material before making any order. If the testing confirms that the drug is what the pharmacy claims, that specific lot is approved for compounding. The pharmacy's finished-product formulations "are tested for potency, antimicrobial effectiveness, container closure integrity, method suitability, and undergo endotoxin and sterility testing before they can be sent to any patient," he says.

Some providers and patients say that despite the lessened FDA oversight, compounding pharmacies may be the best option many people have to get the medication they want at the price they want. "I would argue that the drug makers have overpriced their drug, and compounding pharmacies have been the only reason that those prices have come down over the past three years or so," Brunner says.

Of course, you could argue that you get what you pay for. After receiving unhelpful, automated emails from her telehealth site, Kinkade finally got a response from a nurse practitioner who had a suggestion for why the tirzepatide had made her so sick: it may have had to do with the fact that the telehealth site had switched the compounding pharmacy it used. She says that the nurse practitioner emailed her that different pharmacies can prepare the same drug at different concentrations, even with the same prescribed dose, and that she accidentally might have gotten a much stronger dose of tirzepatide than she'd been used to taking. If she developed severe or worsening symptoms, the nurse practitioner wrote, Kinkade should seek urgent medical care right away. The email did not tell her whether she should take any more doses of the medication.

Kinkade decided to lower the dose she was taking on her own, and she hasn't had bad side effects since.

She hesitates to return to telehealth or compounding pharmacies since her experience. Kinkade recently went to her annual checkup, and her doctor was impressed by how much weight she’d lost, and how good her glucose and other numbers looked. This time, he agreed to prescribe her a brand-name GLP-1.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/07/compounding-pharmacies-weight-loss-drugs/

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Health | Exercise & Fitness

What Hanging from a Bar for 30 Seconds Can Do for Your Body

Most people leave the monkey bars behind with childhood. Yet hanging from a bar—right-side up, don't worry—may be one youthful habit worth picking back up, especially if you spend your days hunched over your desk and phone. (Guilty.)

"We look at kids on a playground—what are they doing?" says Australian physiotherapist Daniel Vadnal, owner of FitnessFAQs, who posts instructive videos on Instagram and YouTube. "They don't need to be told to hang. They just intuitively do it."

A few years ago, Vadnal persuaded his grandmother, now 93, to try a supported hang. That means gripping a bar overhead with straight arms but keeping your feet planted on the floor, rather than dangling your entire body weight. She was skeptical: She hadn't even raised her arms fully overhead since she was a kid. But after just 30 seconds, she felt taller and looser—and found it easier to reach her kitchen cabinets.

Here's what hanging can do for your body, how to keep your feet planted while you build strength, and why just 30 seconds is long enough.

It gives your upper body a stretch

At its simplest, hanging means gripping a secure overhead pull-up bar—the kind that can be installed in a doorway—with straight arms while supporting some or all of your body weight. You remain right-side up: Your hands are above your head, and your feet point

toward the floor or remain planted on it. Hanging upside down, known as inversion, is an entirely different exercise. “It’s fairly simple, but it’s not easy,” says Hazel Anderson, a physical therapist and faculty member at the University of St. Augustine for Health Sciences in Austin.

Whether your feet stay planted for support or lift off the floor, there are two ways to position your upper body. “The passive hang is, as the name suggests, just relaxed,” Vadnal says. “You’re letting nature, gravity, your body do whatever it wants.” Your shoulders move toward your ears, creating a stretch through the shoulders, arms, and trunk.

An active hang requires more effort. “You want to think of trying to bring your shoulder blades down away from your ears,” Vadnal says. That engages the muscles around the shoulders and back, creating more stability. Your elbows remain straight—and your feet can remain planted or off the floor—in either type of hang.

Vadnal considers passive and active hangs opposite ends of a spectrum. A passive hang still requires enough muscle effort to remain safely attached to the bar; an active one involves “really making a concerted effort” to hold yourself in position. He recommends choosing the amount of engagement that feels most comfortable for your body.

Reaching overhead may feel especially satisfying after all those hours slumped over your desk. Hanging “stretches all the tight muscles that we tend to have through the pecs, through the triceps on the back of the arms, as well as the lats,” Vadnal says. You’ll likely find it leaves you feeling a little taller—and less scrunched up through the shoulders.

That doesn’t mean 30 seconds on a bar will permanently correct your posture or treat back or shoulder pain; those claims haven’t been established in strong clinical trials. But hanging moves your

upper body into a position it might not visit very often, which helps explain why people often step down feeling looser.

It makes your grip work

A hang might look passive, but your hands and forearms are busy keeping you attached to the bar. “First and foremost, it supports grip endurance,” Anderson says. “It’s helping with grip strength, but more with the endurance of being able to hold on to the bar.”

That endurance is useful for everything from carrying groceries to working toward a pull-up. “The hands, fingers, and forearms serve as a link to our back,” Vadnal says. Strengthening that link helps prepare you to support—and eventually pull—your body weight.

Research on short, recreational hangs is limited, and most studies involve climbers. In a small 2026 study, 11 climbers hung on until their grip gave out. As they got tired, their shoulders and other upper-body muscles increasingly pitched in to keep them on the bar.

Another randomized trial found that when experienced climbers hung by their fingers for eight weeks, with progressively more weight attached to the body, some measures of grip strength improved. The study involved extra weight and a climbing hold—not beginners attempting a relaxed 30-second hang—but it supports the idea that regularly asking your hands to hold you up can make them better at the job.

Grip strength is also widely used as a marker of overall health. “We do know that grip strength is correlated with longevity,” Vadnal says. In a study of nearly 140,000 adults across 17 countries, weaker grip was associated with a higher risk of death and cardiovascular disease.

That doesn’t mean hanging longer will make you live longer, Vadnal adds. Think of it as one useful signal—not a path to immortality.

Your feet can stay on the floor

Beginners don’t need to hover heroically above the ground. When you’re starting out, the bar is—quite literally—low. “I love the addition of a little step stool or platform,” Anderson says. Hold the bar with both hands, bend your knees slightly, and keep enough weight in your feet that the stretch feels manageable. You can gradually allow your arms to support more of you as you become comfortable.

“You definitely don’t need to jump straight to 30-second hangs all at once,” Anderson says. She recommends starting with a 10-second supported hang and repeating it three to five times, resting briefly between attempts. From there, work toward the 30-second goal. Vadnal likes three 30-second sets, but only after choosing a variation easy enough to complete with control.

Begin with your hands about shoulder-width apart. “That’s most comfortable for pretty much everyone,” Vadnal says, though you can move your hands wider or narrower based on what feels best. Wrap your thumbs underneath the bar to make your grip more secure.

If the typical overhand position bothers your shoulders, try a neutral grip, with your palms facing each other. Many gyms have parallel handles that allow for it, and gymnastics rings will rotate to accommodate your joints. Vadnal calls it “probably the most friendly position for the shoulders.”

Decide whether a passive or slightly more active hang feels better, and don’t worry about matching someone else’s position. Forcing your shoulders farther overhead than they can comfortably go may

leave them sore or irritated, Vadnal says. Let your range of motion improve gradually instead.

Most importantly, remember to breathe. Anderson advises using “slow, controlled breaths” and making sure you’re not holding your air in, whether you’re a beginner or an expert. It’s easy to get so focused on staying on the bar that your whole body clenches up; a few steady breaths can help you relax into the hang.

“Don’t chase the clock,” Anderson says. If your form changes or you can no longer control the hang, put your feet down, rest, and try again.

Know when to let go

Hanging should feel like work—not like you’re about to injure yourself. “We should feel a stretching sensation; we should feel fatigued,” Vadnal says. “We shouldn’t feel pain.” Put your feet down if you experience sharp or persistent pain, numbness, tingling, or weakness.

Those symptoms are signs to stop, not to push through. Talk to a doctor or a physical therapist before trying again. Some people should seek guidance before they ever reach for the bar: Anderson recommends medical clearance for anyone who recently had shoulder surgery or an injury involving the neck, shoulders, elbows, wrists, or trunk. The same applies to people with shoulder instability, pain when reaching overhead, cardiovascular concerns, or uncontrolled high blood pressure.

Osteoporosis doesn’t automatically make hanging off-limits. But because a fall could have more serious consequences, Anderson says, it’s particularly important to keep your feet supported and get personalized guidance.

Anderson recommends practicing two or three times a week on nonconsecutive days, which allows the muscles to recover. There’s no need to progress from zero hanging to auditioning for Cirque du Soleil. Add time or body weight gradually, and take a day off if your hands, forearms, or shoulders remain unusually sore.

If you like hanging, Vadnal suggests keeping a bar somewhere you’ll regularly see it, like in your laundry room. “It’s like daily hygiene,” he says. “You brush your teeth; hanging is a good thing, too.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/08/25/hanging-from-bar-benefits/

Health | Public Health

Why Dangerous Fungi Are on the Rise

A microbiological culture of the yeast Candida auris.TopMicrobialStock/Getty Images

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Narrated by TIME AI.

In the winter of 2015, Dr. Tom Chiller received a call from public-health officials in Britain.

They were panicking. A new fungus was causing devastating infections at a large London hospital. “They weren’t able to get rid of it,” says Chiller, who was then chief of the fungal-diseases branch at the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC). “They didn’t know what to do.”

The British officials said the fungus—a kind of yeast called *Candida auris*—appeared to be spreading from patient to patient. The officials said they were going to shut down parts of the hospital to curb its transmission. “That was just mind-boggling,” Chiller says.

At first he was more confused than alarmed. *Candida* is a kind of yeast that causes some of the most common fungal conditions, including thrush and vaginal yeast infections. Some species can cause severe illnesses, including bloodstream infections. But Chiller knew of no *Candida* species—indeed, no life-threatening fungus of any kind—that could spread so easily among people.

“I’ll never forget that call,” he says. “At first, I didn’t really believe it. Suddenly we have a yeast acting like a bacteria? It was weird.”

First discovered by doctors in 2009 in the ear of a patient in Japan, *Candida auris* behaves differently from most other fungi. It can survive at higher temperatures and in saltier environments, making nooks like a human ear, armpit, and groin ideal places to grow. It is exceptionally sticky and clings doggedly to people’s skin and hair follicles, and to surfaces—including slick ones, like hospital floors and beds, that are designed to repel germs. It is highly resistant to antifungal drugs, hard to kill with standard disinfectants, and can cause terrible, often deadly illnesses. Also, as British officials were starting to notice in 2015, it spreads easily through physical contact between people and via contaminated surfaces.

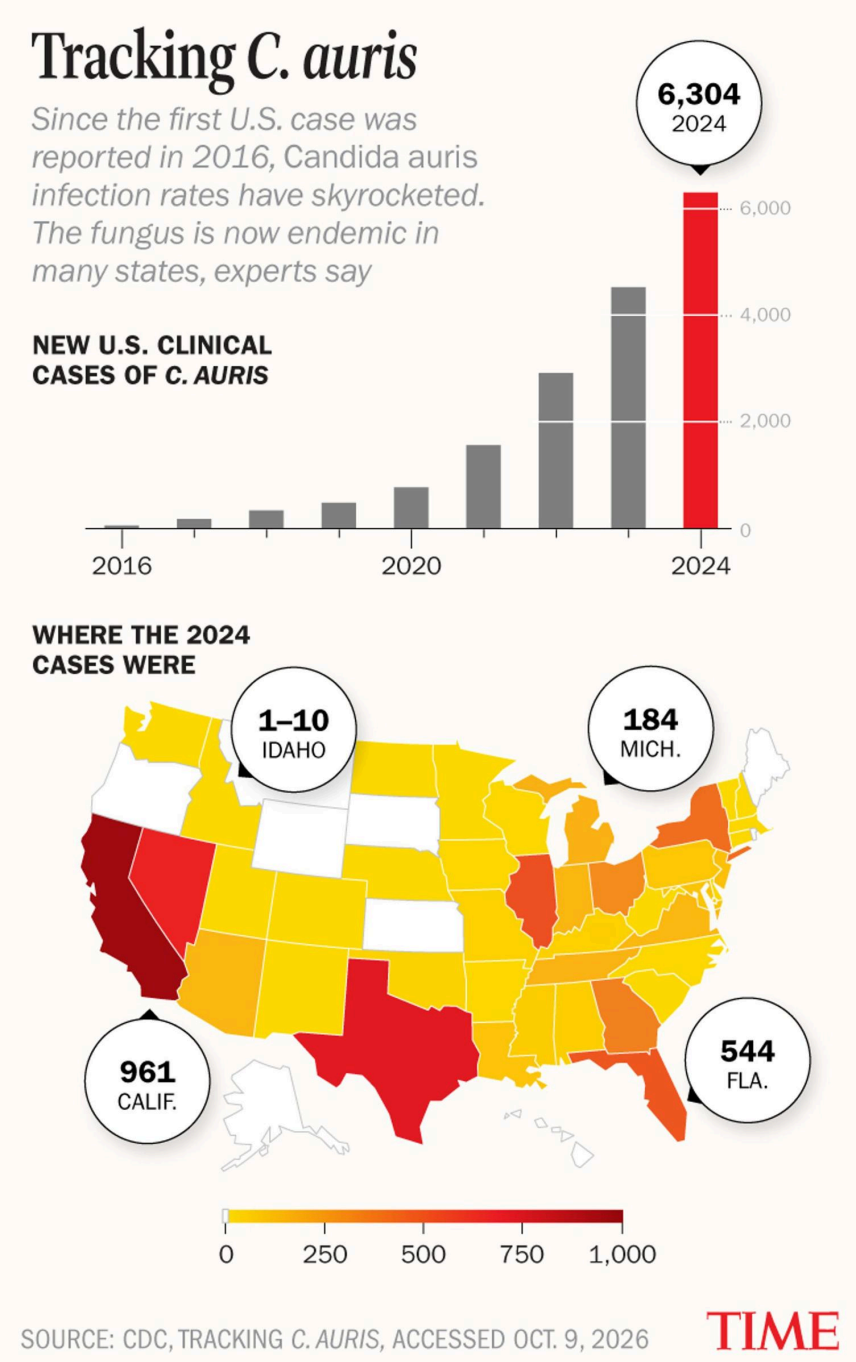
At the time of the call, though, much about *Candida auris* remained unknown. A few countries had reported a smattering of infections, but it hadn’t seemed like a big deal. No cases had yet been reported in the U.S. “It was a wake-up call,” Chiller says now. “We realized that, huh, maybe this little ear fungus isn’t just a little ear fungus anymore.”

In the decade since that phone call, that realization has cemented. When about 200 people—mostly doctors and researchers—attended a three-day conference about fungal diseases near Denver in September, *Candida auris* was the first topic on the agenda. To a nonscientist, the talks were dry, technical presentations on the pathogenesis and epidemiology of the disease, but to the attendees—and “almost everyone who works in mycology is here,” said Dr.

Luis Ostrosky-Zeichner, an infectious-disease specialist at UTHealth Houston—they were red flags we should all be taking seriously.

Candida auris has rapidly gained ground since 2015. It has sickened tens of thousands of people in over 80 countries and six continents. The World Health Organization (WHO) has designated it one of the world's highest-priority fungal threats. The CDC on Oct. 27 listed *Candida auris* as one of four top-priority drug-resistant pathogens that require "urgent and aggressive action." Thousands of cases are now reported in the U.S. every year. The CDC said this summer that the fungus had already infected more than 3,000 people this year in 27 states. Up to 60% of people who are infected die.

"In some U.S. states, it's just endemic now. It's there to stay," Chiller says.



Deadly fungal diseases were once considered very rare, but the proliferation of *Candida auris* points to a troubling trend: dangerous fungi are increasingly finding new opportunities to infect us, and human activity is spurring them on.

From the climate we're warming to the medical treatments we use, we are creating conditions that allow fungal pathogens to thrive, infectious-disease experts say. Rising global temperatures, they say, likely led to the emergence of *Candida auris* and are driving the

evolution of other fungal pathogens never seen before. Changing weather patterns are pushing some fungi to expand their geographic range, and the overuse of antifungals in medicine, agriculture, and livestock farming has driven them to develop resistance to these drugs.

“We are creating an environment that is favoring pathogenic fungi and drug resistance,” says Dr. Andrej Spec, a fungal-disease specialist at Washington University School of Medicine in St. Louis. “That means they are likely becoming better at infecting us, and also at evading our treatments. That’s a bad combination.”

Fungi are ubiquitous organisms. They live in, on, and all around us. Every day, we inhale thousands—if not millions—of fungal spores. There are an estimated 6 million species of fungi on the planet, but only about 300 of them cause diseases in people. “We are protected by our temperature and our immunity,” says Dr. Arturo Casadevall, chair of microbiology and immunology at the Johns Hopkins School of Public Health. The human body is too hot for most fungi to thrive, but as the earth warms, fungi are adapting.

Researchers think *Candida auris*, which likely originated in marine ecosystems, evolved a tolerance to salty conditions and high temperatures over time. The yeast can now survive at 107°F.

Candida auris is not the only threat finding hot new hosts. A new fungal pathogen is disfiguring cats and people in South America, and certain molds, which once infected only plants, are now sickening people too. Spec published a report in 2021 describing the first case of a person infected by a mold that had previously been known to damage only trees. Since then, two more people in the U.S. have been infected, Spec says. “It’s gone from never causing human disease in the history of medicine to three new cases of it in the last five years,” he says.

In October, the CDC said that cases of a different mold—a brain-attacking variety—have jumped fourfold in the past two years. “This is a nasty pathogen,” Spec says. It infects even healthy people and causes brain abscesses that in up to 70% of cases are fatal.

“We’re seeing a lot of these molds that were once rare pathogens becoming more common,” Spec says. “A lot of us are leaning toward the idea that this is probably being driven by climate change.”

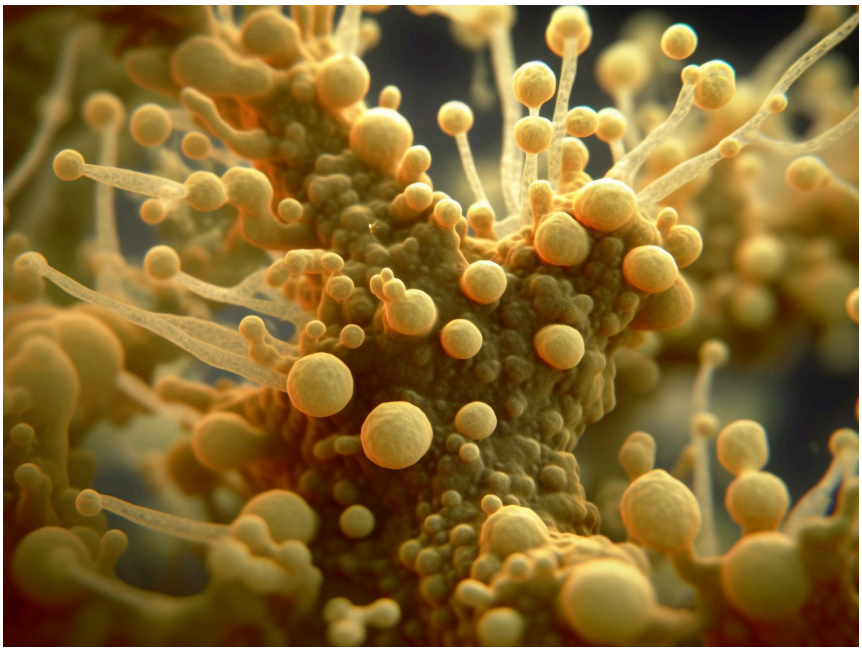
Spec and other doctors are working with public-health officials, patient advocates, and drug developers to try to stem the rise of threatening fungi. They’ve made some progress in recent years: raising awareness, doing more surveillance, and developing new drugs and tests, but the challenge is formidable.

As fungi develop mechanisms to better infect us, more people are becoming vulnerable to serious fungal diseases—because of advancements in medicine. Today, to fight autoimmune conditions and diseases like cancer, millions of people take drugs that suppress their immune systems. But immunocompromised people are at higher risk of contracting severe fungal infections. Thanks in part to those therapies, the growing population of immunocompromised people in the U.S. is now estimated to number at least 7 million.

“We have people who have immune conditions like multiple sclerosis, Crohn’s disease, and rheumatoid arthritis who might have died from these diseases in the past but aren’t dead thanks to these therapies. But they’re also immunosuppressed, so we have a bigger pool of people who are at risk,” Spec says.

More people are also being kept alive by invasive medical devices, such as heart-lung machines and ventilators, which can create pathways for germs including fungi to enter the body. “We’re

making all this medical progress," Casadevall says, "but that progress comes at a cost."



Candida auris fungus, illustrationScience Photo Library—Reuters

Ryan Zwick, a healthy 22-year-old, had just graduated from nursing school when COVID nearly struck him dead in December 2023. The virus, which research shows increases the risk of cardiovascular disease, severely damaged his heart.

Zwick spent a week in an intensive-care unit in Las Vegas before he was airlifted to a hospital in San Diego to receive more advanced care. He was intubated and sedated; his lungs, kidneys, and heart had all started to fail.

He was attached to a heart-lung machine, a life-support device that pumps a patient's blood outside the body, via tubes placed into his sternum. "His chest was basically open for like a week," his wife Emmy remembers.

Candida auris took advantage.

When Zwick finally woke up more than a month after being admitted to the hospital, doctors told him he had a severe *Candida auris* infection. The yeast, they said, likely sneaked into his body

through the tubes in his chest. “It got into my bloodstream and kept causing a lot of issues throughout my body,” he says.

He was treated aggressively with antifungal drugs, which kept the infection under control. But the fungus lingered.

Zwick was discharged from the hospital in April 2024, but he returned to the emergency room a couple of weeks later because blisters had appeared at the incision site on his chest. He soon learned that the *Candida auris* infection was causing osteomyelitis, a serious and painful condition in which bone tissue becomes inflamed. “They took out a bunch of bone and stuff, and put me on more antifungals,” he says.

More than two years later, Zwick, who works as a nurse in New Hampshire, continues to receive weekly infusions of a potent antifungal drug to manage his infection. His doctors have warned him that he will likely have to take them for life. “It’s basically chronic now,” says Zwick, who still sometimes has swelling and blistering at the incision site.

Zwick worries that available antifungal drugs could one day lose their sting. *Candida auris* is highly resistant to many antifungals; a growing number of infections are “pan-resistant,” which means no medicines are effective against them. “I just hope these drugs keep working for me,” Zwick says.

When *Candida auris* first emerged in the U.S. a decade ago, it was a very rare and often severe disease whose victims were usually sick, elderly, and immunocompromised people in hospitals and nursing homes. But the yeast has been expanding its reach: not just infecting more people, but a broader range of them, and causing a wider variety of illnesses too.

“Ten years ago, we’d maybe see one *Candida auris* patient every few months,” says UTHealth’s Ostrosky-Zeichner. “Now, we have

several cases per day in Houston." Texas, New York, Nevada, Florida, and California are among the U.S. states with the highest number of cases.

More young people, like Zwick, and people who aren't immunocompromised are getting infected, doctors say. The yeast is also starting to cause new types of hard-to-treat infections. Spec says that this year, for the first time, he treated a woman with a vaginal yeast infection caused by *Candida auris.* She had diabetes that was well-controlled and was otherwise healthy, says Spec.

The woman had come to see him after getting recurrent yeast infections that hadn't responded to standard treatments, he says. She recovered only after being treated for several days with an IV antifungal drug more powerful than what is usually used to treat such infections, Spec says.

Vaginal yeast infections are very common, with an estimated 3 in 4 women having at least one in their lifetime. A class of antifungals known as azoles are typically used to treat such infections, either as a cream, suppository, or oral pill, but *Candida auris* is more than 90% resistant to azole drugs. "It's no joke when you have to tell a woman that she has a vaginal yeast infection for which you usually take one pill and move on, but in her case, she needs to get on IV medication," Spec says.

Doctors say *Candida auris* is also emerging as the cause of another common disease: urinary tract infections (UTIs), which roughly half of women will experience at least once. Doctors have known that *Candida auris* can cause UTIs in people with catheters, but they are now seeing cases of people with tough-to-treat infections who don't have any medical devices or major health complications.

Public-health experts worry that the fungus could become as widespread as pathogens like MRSA: methicillin-resistant *Staphylococcus aureus,* a superbug bacteria.

“Initially, we tried to stomp it out, but we realized early on that *Candida auris* was here to stay. It was going to be more like MRSA,” says Chiller. “MRSA used to be hospital-only, and now it’s on every skin boil on the high school wrestling team.”

Self-described ‘fun-guy’ Tom Chiller tosses a mushroom plushie in his Atlanta homeIrina Rozovsky for TIME

After Chiller got off the phone with his British counterparts in 2015, he went on a quest to better understand the fungus that he suspected would soon invade the U.S. He first wanted to know if *Candida auris* was already on U.S. soil but doctors had just missed it. Under his direction, the CDC sent out an alert to hospitals and researchers, asking them to test samples of unidentified fungal pathogens in their repositories going back decades. “We didn’t find *Candida auris* historically,” he says.

The CDC also collaborated with public-health officials in parts of Asia, Africa, and South America, where *Candida auris* cases had been detected. Together, they studied samples of the fungus in an attempt to understand how it emerged. They discovered something remarkable: at least three distinct strains of *Candida auris* appeared nearly simultaneously, over the course of a few years, but separately—in different corners of the globe.

Many fungal-disease specialists and researchers now think climate change likely drove the yeast's transformation from non-threatening environmental fungus to deadly pathogen. "It's hard to explain the emergence of *Candida auris* simultaneously on all these continents and not include climate change as part of it. It just has to be. There's no other good explanation," says Dr. Peter Pappas, an infectious-disease doctor at the University of Alabama at Birmingham.

Fungi are sensitive to heat, but they are also very adaptable to rising temperatures. In laboratory experiments, researchers have put different fungi in incubators and, by steadily raising the temperature, have spawned fungi that are more tolerant to higher heat.

"It's actually not that hard," says Casadevall, who studies how fungi cause disease and was the first to publish the theory that global warming spurred *Candida auris*' rise. "The slower you raise the temperature, the more the fungi can tolerate it. It doesn't take a lot of mutations," he says.

A study he published with colleagues last year showed how different microclimates within the same city can trigger changes in fungi. "We went to Baltimore and looked for fungi on the sidewalk in a cool part of town, where they had nice trees and it's shaded, and then the same fungus in a warm part of town," Casadevall says. "We found that even within one city, just two miles away, the fungi from the warm neighborhood grow at higher temperatures. So, it's happening."

Fungi are already a major threat to many plants, insects, and cold-blooded animals. Frogs everywhere are being wiped out by a fungal disease; rice and banana crops have been decimated by fungi; and millions of bats, which drop their body temperature when they hibernate, have recently died in North America because

of a deadly fungus. Until now, however, most mammals have been protected by our high body temperatures.

The emergence of *Candida auris* is a “shot across the bow of humanity that these things can happen,” Casadevall says. “We can have an organism come out of nowhere, and begin causing disease.”

A sample test for Valley Fever in the Carrizo Plain National Monument in Santa Margarita, Calif.Carolyn Van Houten—The Washington Post/Getty Images

Many other fungi are changing in ways that are worrying and, in some cases, dumbfounding doctors. As temperatures rise and rainfall patterns shift, some are spreading to new places. The soil-dwelling fungus *Histoplasma,* which had historically been confined in the U.S. to central and southern regions, has been steadily moving northward, eastward, and westward. U.S. cases have increased twofold in the past decade.

Valley fever, caused by inhaling microscopic fungal spores, is estimated to sicken up to 360,000 people in the U.S. yearly. The fungus was primarily found in the arid American Southwest until about a decade or two ago, when it began spreading to states like Washington, once considered too wet or cold for it.

Even fungal diseases considered mundane and easily treated, like ringworm, are evolving in alarming ways, doctors say. A new species of ringworm that can be resistant to all antifungal drugs has been spreading from the Indian subcontinent to the Middle East, Europe, and the U.S. in recent years. This new ringworm, which is highly contagious, causes chronic, inflamed, and itchy skin plaques all over the body.

“Think of athlete’s foot, but it’s now athlete’s body, and it’s untreatable,” Chiller says. He predicts this new disease, which experts think evolved in response to the overuse of over-the-counter antifungal medications, will become the predominant ringworm found globally in the next decade.

In Brazil and South America, outbreaks of a fungus that causes a disfiguring and sometimes fatal skin disease have been sickening cats, dogs, and people. Like *Candida auris*, the pathogen has mysterious origins. The fungus was first identified as a threat in 1998 after an outbreak in Rio de Janeiro. First, cats started showing up to the city’s clinics very sick and covered with lesions. Then, people and dogs did too. Infectious-disease doctors identified the culprit of these illnesses as a type of *Sporothrix* fungus. Infected cats were spreading the disease to dogs and humans through scratches, bites, and even sneezes.

That explanation didn’t seem to make any sense at first, says Dallas Smith, a fungal-diseases scientist at CDC who tracks emerging pathogens including *Sporothrix.*

A species of *Sporothrix* fungus called *Sporothrix schenckii* had long been known to doctors and scientists. The pathogen causes what is often referred to as “rose gardener’s disease” because the fungus, which lives in the environment, typically infects people who work with dirt and plants. “Gardeners would get pricked by a rose thorn, and that would provide the opening for the fungus to enter,” Smith says.

The fungus was known to infect cats, but that was exceedingly uncommon. The disease itself was also very rare. At the largest hospital for infectious diseases in Rio de Janeiro, the Evandro Chagas National Institute of Infectious Diseases, doctors typically saw two to three cases a year before 1998, says Dr. Dayvison Freitas, an infectious-dermatology researcher at the hospital.

But seemingly out of nowhere, something incited the emergence of a more virulent *Sporothrix* species spread by cats and not plants. It isn't clear what pushed it to evolve to so effectively infect cats. "Is it because of climate change or environmental change or some other pressures that we don't understand?" Smith says.

Sporothrix brasiliensis was named as a separate species in 2007. Infections caused by the fungus can result in multiple lesions in people, sometimes all over the body and face. It almost always leaves lasting scars, which are often dark and raised, says Freitas.

In up to 10% of cases, usually involving elderly or immunocompromised people, the fungus can enter the bloodstream and cause destructive illnesses. "The fungus can affect any organ or system, including the bones, joints, lungs, throat, brain. It can cause a kind of meningitis," Freitas says. "If this happens, it is very, very severe, and the death rate is high."

Brazil has seen an explosion of the fungus in recent years. "Cats are spreading this disease among themselves, but also to humans at an alarmingly high rate," Smith says.

From 1998 to 2001, fewer than 180 people, concentrated around Rio de Janeiro, fell sick with the disease. In recent years, thousands of people across the country are infected annually, Smith says.

The disease is now even infecting people in remote villages in the Amazon, Freitas says, and has emerged in other countries too. Cases of *Sporothrix brasiliensis* have been steadily sprouting up

across South America in countries including Argentina, Paraguay, and Chile. Uruguay experienced its first outbreak of the disease in 2025, and Peru reported its first case this year, Smith says. “It’s just a matter of time before it ends up in the United States” and beyond, he says.

Sporothrix, says Chiller, is one of a growing number of fungi that are “dramatically changing our understanding of how we think fungi are supposed to act.”

At the Denver conference**,** a line of scientists followed Chiller wherever he went. Everyone there wanted to bend his ear. Chiller was decked out in his usual professional attire: a well-cut jacket with a colorful, bespoke fungi-print lining and a matching pocket square. (Chiller, whose grandfather was a tailor, has about 15 fungi-themed custom jackets.)

“In every generation, there tends to be a few people who are a force multiplier,” says Spec. “They change the field. In the case of mycology, the success that exists is often due to Tom Chiller.”

Chiller has been working for decades to draw the world’s attention to fungi’s gathering threat. He was the deputy director of the CDC’s fungal-diseases branch for about 10 years and its chief for another decade. Under his leadership, the department doubled in size to about 45 people and expanded its work to include surveillance of priority fungal diseases, including *Candida auris,* and research into emerging pathogens, as well as new treatments and diagnostic tools.

He was instrumental in the development and widespread use of a cheap, simple, and accurate test, using just a pinprick of blood, for *Cryptococcus*—an environmental fungus that can cause meningitis. “It’s definitely saved tens of thousands of lives,” Chiller says. “I’m very proud of that.”

Chiller left the CDC last year after 25 years at the agency, months after Robert F. Kennedy Jr. was named head of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services. Chiller says he had been growing increasingly disenchanted at the agency since COVID. “During the pandemic, it was turmoil for everybody. CDC took a big hit reputationally,” he says. Then Kennedy took the helm, and Chiller’s team was cut by about a quarter, he says. “We had to prioritize what we could do.”

Chiller says he felt “handcuffed” by restrictions imposed on CDC staff in the spring of 2025. “They cut all our travel, they canceled all meetings. We didn’t really have budgets,” he recalls. “I thought to myself, If this is the future, it’s not for me.” Chiller is now chief medical officer at IMMY, a company that develops tests for fungal diseases. He’s also a board member of the nonprofit Global Action Fund for Fungal Infections and of MyCARE, a fungal-disease patient-advocacy organization. Now, he gets to do what he loves most: advocating for fungal-disease awareness.

In September, he attended a roundtable discussion about fungal diseases with Kennedy and other U.S. health officials. Chiller, who helped coordinate the meeting, says it was the first time in his career that he had been in a room with a U.S. Health Secretary to talk only about fungus. That felt like progress, he says.

Chiller knows just how critical it is for health leaders and professionals to be familiar with fungi. “Think Fungus” was the catchphrase of the CDC’s first Fungal Disease Awareness Week, which Chiller helped launch in 2017. Doctors often miss fungal diseases because they fail to think of them, research shows.

Though the spread of fungi in a warming world may seem like an impossible foe, there is hope in the fact that diagnosing fungal infections early makes it much more likely that a patient will survive—and researchers, including Chiller, are working to help patients take advantage of that edge.

They’ve got a long way to go: a 2019 paper showed that almost half of some 270 patients in Arizona with valley fever—a fungal disease Chiller studied as a young doctor—weren’t diagnosed correctly for a month or more.

Justin John at the hospital with his mother where he was being treated for Valley fever.Courtesy of Justin John

Justin John lived that nightmare. The 27-year-old software engineer from Arizona was wrongly diagnosed with COVID, the common cold, and irritable bowel syndrome before doctors realized—more than six months later—that he was sick with valley fever.

There were “lesions literally everywhere inside my body,” he says. After lumps caused by the fungus started appearing on his forehead

and neck, doctors discovered that the fungus had eaten holes through parts of his spine and skull. He underwent two surgeries to insert a metal plate into his forehead, and replace a part of his vertebrae with a metal disc. “The vertebra was so dissolved, they couldn’t save any of it,” he says.

John says he was healthy, active, and had no underlying medical conditions before he got sick. “It’s in the dirt. You can get it anywhere at any time,” he says. “I could have gotten it when I was walking to Walmart.”

Blood tests are currently used to diagnose valley fever, but false negative results are common, causing many missed diagnoses. IMMY is developing a new rapid urine test for the disease that it says will be easier to administer and more accurate. “So many patients, even here in Arizona where this disease is endemic, get missed,” says Dr. Fariba Donovan, a valley fever specialist at the University of Arizona who treated John. “This test could really decrease that delay in diagnosis.”

These are steps in the right direction, but Chiller says we need to take greater strides if we want to win in the race against fungi. Many decades ago, after encountering very sick and dying valley fever patients, Chiller says he “learned a lot about how devastating and complex fungal diseases can be.” He’s still waiting for the rest of us to catch up.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/27/why-dangerous-fungi-are-on-the-rise/

Ideas

- **The War in Iran Will Make It Harder for Americans to Stay Warm This Winter**
  With no end to the war in sight and an approaching winter that will see a rise in energy demand and costs, policymakers need to move quickly to offer relief to families, writes Sanya Carley.
- **Family Matters: The Secret History Behind Why Vincent van Gogh Cut Off His Ear**
  "There is a world of personal stories behind the paintings of Vincent van Gogh, and they reaffirm an old adage: we can’t separate the art from the artist,” writes Joan Martelli.
- **Why Satire Is No Laughing Matter**
  Sacha Baron Cohen on the power of comedy in a serious time

Ideas | Money

The War in Iran Will Make It Harder for Americans to Stay Warm This Winter

Sanya Carley is a Presidential Distinguished Professor, Faculty Director of the Kleinman Center for Energy Policy, and Vice Provost for Climate at the University of Pennsylvania.

The aftermath of a snowstorm in Reading, Pa. on Dec. 17, 2020.Ben Hasty—MediaNews Group/Reading Eagle via Getty Images

Sanya Carley is a Presidential Distinguished Professor, Faculty Director of the Kleinman Center for Energy Policy, and Vice Provost for Climate at the University of Pennsylvania.

As America's war with Iran continues and winter approaches, families already struggling to cover rising living costs could face another financial shock: utility bills to keep their homes warm. Americans are already feeling the pain at the pump. Filling a 14-gallon gas tank now costs about $62, compared with $44 a year ago, based on AAA's national averages. For someone using a full tank each week, that would mean roughly $912 in additional annual fuel costs if the price gap persisted.

But the war's cost burden is affecting more than just gasoline prices. The war in Iran is also pushing up the cost of heating our homes. The National Energy Assistance Directors Association projects that home energy costs will rise by 8.7% this winter—more than twice the latest annual inflation rate of 3.4%. Nearly 5 million households in the U.S., mostly in the Northeast, depend on heating oil to heat their homes.

If families felt their bills had grown substantially higher over the past five years, they are not mistaken. Energy costs have already increased nearly 30% on average since 2021. On top of that, heating oil costs are projected to rise by more than 31% this winter, largely because of the sharp increase in heating oil prices driven by the war in Iran.

Working families and older individuals already struggling to make ends meet will be hit the hardest financially and will be forced to make life-or-death decisions. Cold homes can raise blood pressure and increase the risk of heart attacks and strokes, particularly among older adults.

The pressure extends beyond the heating bill. Because diesel powers the trucks that move goods across the country, higher oil prices hit every corner of the economy, making everything from groceries to clothing to household essentials more expensive.

CNBC conducted a poll earlier this year and found that 63% of adults living in the U.S. are living paycheck-to-paycheck. For households already stretching every dollar, there may be no discretionary spending left to cut.

But heating is essential. When a family cannot afford heat, their need to stay warm does not disappear. Too often, this leads families to make dangerous compromises. Some keep their homes uncomfortably cold, while others turn to dangerous coping strategies like running space heaters, flaring gas stoves, burning

trash in the home, or sitting in running cars in enclosed spaces. These choices can expose families to serious harm inside the homes where they should feel safest.

In research my colleagues and I conducted during the first year of the pandemic, more than half of low-income households engaged in survival-focused coping strategies. While some families turn to dangerous ways to keep warm at home, other families unable to pay their bills often take on debt or sacrifice other necessities like seeking medical care or buying food. Most of these households use multiple strategies, revealing how financial hardship can force people to make several compromises at once.

These consequences can also stretch far beyond the winter season. Debts incurred during a season with high energy costs will have to be repaid later, with interest and fees leaving less money available for the next bill or family emergency. Significant debt may also result in utility disconnection once winter shut-off protections no longer apply.

Prolonged high fuel prices caused by the Iran war will only deepen this hardship.

Households have limited control over the heating systems they depend on, with renters generally unable to replace them and homeowners on tight budgets unable to afford upgrades. Meanwhile, a military conflict with Iran that more than three in four Americans believe is not worth the financial burden it's created continues to hurt families who are absorbing the consequences at the pump, at the grocery store, and at home.

Families who cannot afford their energy bills could see relief through government programs like the Low Income Home Energy Assistance Program if it were funded at higher levels and with expanded eligibility. Currently, the program only reaches a fraction of families in need, and the need is growing significantly. An

increase in funding now would mean more families seeing relief before they have to go into debt or endure unsafe winter conditions.

Longer term, reducing America's dependence on oil could help families save on energy costs. The International Renewable Energy Agency found that 91% of utility-scale renewable power capacity commissioned worldwide in 2024 produced electricity more cheaply than the cheapest new fossil-fuel alternative. This means the development of new clean energy sources will provide greater financial benefits to families rather than polluting, expensive, and outdated sources of energy like oil and gas.

With no end to the war in sight and an approaching winter that will see a rise in energy demand and costs, policymakers need to move quickly to offer relief to families. Americans deserve future-focused solutions that include diversifying our energy sources so that no future wars or shocks to fossil fuel sources can impact the United States' ability to afford necessities.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/07/the-war-in-iran-will-make-it-harder-for-americans-to-stay-warm-this-winter/

Ideas | Weekend Essay

Family Matters: The Secret History Behind Why Vincent van Gogh Cut Off His Ear

Photo-Illustration by TIME (Source Image: Tolga Akmen—AFP/Getty Images)

Joan Martelli is the author of “The Widow Van Gogh.”

After riding a series of escalators to the fifth floor of New York’s Museum of Modern Art, I stepped into a gallery where, on display, were a dozen paintings and lithographs by late-nineteenth and early twentieth-century artists, including Pablo Picasso, Paul Cézanne, and Georges Seurat.

But most visitors were gathered around one explosively colorful painting in swirling shades of light and dark blue, bottle green, and pale gold.

Instantly recognizable.

One of the most famous paintings in the world.

The Starry Night by Vincent van Gogh.

These were the early days of my research about a little-known woman who is key to shedding light on three inevitable questions when it comes to Vincent van Gogh. Why did he cut off his ear? Why did he commit suicide? And how, after dying in obscurity, did he eventually become regarded as one of the world's greatest artists?

Gauging Van Gogh

Watching and talking to people as they engaged with this particular masterpiece seemed an apropos way to gauge the interest of Van Gogh lovers.

I, for one, could remember, as a child, first seeing *The Starry Night* reprinted in one of my parents' art history books. It was my modern art "aha" moment. No one was standing over my shoulder telling me to pay it special attention, but I was mesmerized. The painting became imprinted on my young imagination, and I never forgot it.

As I observed the gallery, I quickly learned my reaction is hardly unique.

A man from Southern California named Paul Duelo was laughing. "I know this painting, and I don't know anything about art," he said with a chuckle, nodding at the crowd standing around *The Starry Night*. "Look at everyone!"

A woman from Seattle stood gazing quietly with her arms folded. Sheri Larison first saw a picture of *The Starry Night* more than 30 years ago in her high school art class. A reproduction of the iconic painting hung in her office. This was her very first time seeing the original.

"It's overwhelming," Larison whispered, with tears in her eyes. "It evokes something. It's magical."

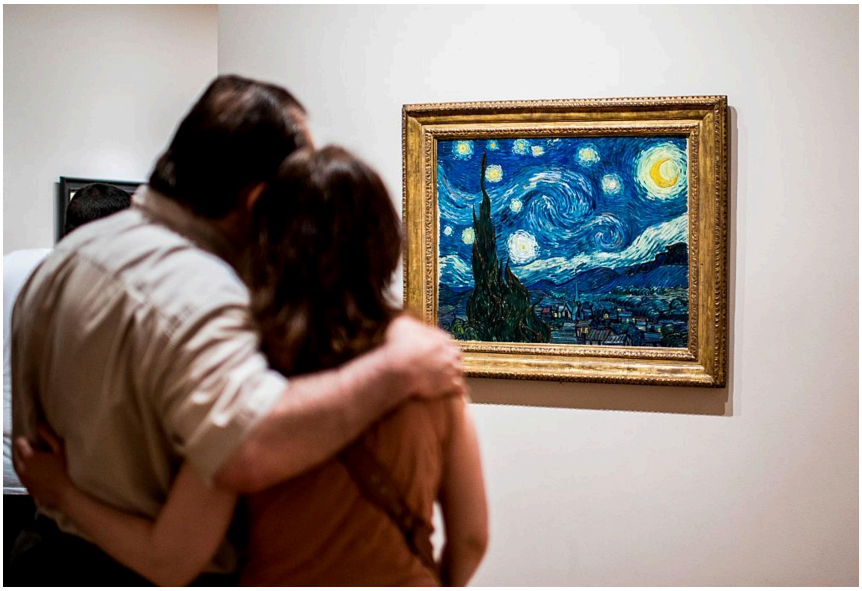
She was interested in the painting's origin story. "His mental health was declining," she said, and that was true, although perhaps also misleading.

Van Gogh painted *The Starry Night* in June of 1889 during a year he spent in a mental asylum in the south of France.

It does not represent an actual place but a compilation of elements —a village, starry sky, moon, dark hills, and a cypress tree—all things that Vincent had seen at one time and brought together in this composition. The sight of stars, he said, always made him dream.

Hanging just to the left of *The Starry Night* was a Paul Gauguin's painting, *The Moon and the Earth*. The juxtaposition provoked a curious thought. Gauguin and Van Gogh lived and worked together in Vincent's yellow house in Arles in the south of France for several weeks. What would the hot-tempered, competitive Gauguin have thought seeing so many people gathered around Vincent's painting at this moment while his was comparatively ignored? And what would Vincent have made of all the attention given to *The Starry Night?*

It is generally believed that it was an argument with Gauguin, who was threatening to quit Arles (in effect abandoning Van Gogh), which spun the mentally unstable Vincent into such a state of despair and frustration that he mutilated himself by slicing off his left ear.



"The Starry Night" by Vincent van Gogh at the the Museum of Modern Art in New York.Victor Fraile —Corbis/Getty Images

The fine art of family matters

But, as I was learning, family matters also very likely played a part in the most notorious instance of self-harm in art history.

It's a tragic story of dependence and the limits of love. And it's where Jo van Gogh-Bonger comes in. Biographical details about her—revealed in her diaries and letters—have only recently been made public by the Van Gogh Museum in Amsterdam. They paint a picture of a determined woman to whom the world of art owes a tremendous debt.

Jo was married to Vincent's younger brother, Theo, who was an art dealer in Paris and Vincent's only source of income. Theo supported Vincent with a monthly allowance, and in exchange Vincent gave Theo his paintings to try to market and sell. The financial arrangement, as it would in most families, put an emotional strain on both brothers. Theo was not rich, and Vincent constantly complained about being broke, with not even enough money for food, and often practically begged his brother for more money.

Over the course of 10 years, Vincent created more than 800 paintings and 700 drawings, desperately hoping for financial independence and commercial success. But in Vincent's lifetime, Theo is known to have sold just one painting: *Red Vineyard at Arles*.

In July of 1890, believing himself a failure as an artist and a man, Vincent shot himself in the chest. He was only 37.

Six months after Vincent's suicide, Theo died from the ravages of syphilis, leaving Jo a young widow with a baby to support, not much money, and an unusual inheritance—Vincent's paintings—more than 400 in total.

They filled the walls of their Paris apartment, were stored in closets, under beds, and at a nearby art supply store. *The Potato Eaters*, *Irises*, *Sunflowers*, self-portraits, and *The Starry Night*. Celebrated as masterpieces today, at the time they were regarded as the unpolished works of a depressed, crazy man and commercially worthless. Jo thought differently. She had no formal art training, but she loved his work and her instincts told her that Vincent was (as Theo had come to believe) a genius.

Jo also inherited hundreds of letters that Vincent wrote and received, most exchanged with Theo. Jo read and re-read those letters, initially to feel closer to Theo, but she was also captivated by Vincent's compassion and intelligence. She decided the world should read them too. It was part of her plan: to organize exhibitions, lobby critics, and publicize the letters, which showed how vulnerable and anguished Vincent was, yes, but also how deliberate he was in his craft and how close Vincent and Theo were to each other. Eventually, in 1914, Jo succeeded in publishing Vincent's letters in an ambitious three-volume book, which today is considered one of the most revealing and important works of art history.

An infamous ear

As much as she would play a vital role in propelling him to fame, Jo was also someone who unwittingly played a part in Vincent's self-destructive descent, something she at times admitted feeling guilt about after his death. Jo understood Vincent was lonely and that he became more isolated after she married his brother.

That infamous act of self-mutilation, when Vincent cut off his ear, happened the very day Vincent likely received the surprising news that Theo and Jo were engaged, triggering what some Van Gogh experts, including Martin Bailey, suspect were unquenchable fears that Theo might eventually abandon him.

And Vincent shot himself just days after a stressful visit with Jo and Theo in Paris. Theo was thinking about quitting his job to start his own business, which meant, for a time, no income. The couple (who by now had a baby son they named after Vincent) hoped to rent a better apartment on a lower floor. But budgets were tight, arguments ensued, and Vincent eventually rushed out of the apartment, unable to shake the thought that he was a burden that Theo would or could no longer bear.

Jo didn't seek to put herself at the center of this story, but she is there, nonetheless. A surprisingly relatable woman (at times insecure, at times doggedly persistent), she courageously stood up to the male-dominated art world as a champion for Vincent and spent 30 years of her life promoting his work and life story in Holland, Germany, France, England, and even, for a time, in America.

Interestingly, of all the paintings Jo inherited, no one—not Jo or Theo or Vincent—considered *The Starry Night* one of Vincent's best. Vincent didn't even sign it. Research recently published by the Van Gogh Museum points out that Vincent signed only about 16% of his paintings, hypothesizing he did so usually when he was

completely satisfied or wanted to make them a gift to friends or family. In the brothers' correspondence, *The Starry Night* was referred to rather than named. Theo called it simply "the village in the moonlight," critically writing to Vincent that "I feel that the search for style takes away the real sentiment of things."

Vincent conceded the painting lacked character and considered it a mistake that "…once again I'm allowing myself to do stars too big…new setback, and I've had enough of that."

Jo also didn't seem to consider *The Starry Night* as especially important. She sold it early on but reacquired it briefly in time for a major exhibition she organized in Amsterdam in 1905. It was painting number 199, called *De Sterren* (The Stars), and it changed hands two more times before MoMA acquired it in 1941. By then, it had been rechristened *The Starry Night.* The name stuck.

There is a world of personal stories behind the paintings of Vincent van Gogh, and they reaffirm an old adage: we can't separate the art from the artist. I believe Jo would agree.

Paul Duelo, the man from California I met while admiring MoMA's *The Starry Night,* lit up when I told him about Jo van Gogh-Bonger.

He had never heard of her before.

But he wanted to know more.

If you or someone you know may be experiencing a mental-health crisis or contemplating suicide, call or text 988.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/17/family-matters-the-secret-history-behind-why-vincent-van-gogh-cut-off-his-ear/

Ideas | Comedy

Why Satire Is No Laughing Matter

Nadav Kander for TIME

Baron Cohen is an actor and filmmaker; his new movie is 'Ali G: Who Iz I?'

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Narrated by TIME AI.

The first time I was introduced to satire, my jaw dropped—and not just because it was the first time I'd ever seen a naked woman.

I was 8 when my older brothers snuck me into a London cinema to see *Monty Python's Life of Brian.* Although my underdeveloped brain may not have fully grasped the critique of religion or internecine fights among political leftists, I loved the feeling of being surrounded by 300 people screaming with laughter.

Over the next few years, I inhaled an array of comedy greats: Peter Sellers, Peter Cook, and *Not the Nine O'Clock News,* with its biting commentary on Thatcherite Britain. Then came a personal breakthrough. At the age of 20, I spent six months studying with an intimidating French clown.

The late Philippe Gaulier was one of the all-time great teachers of clown and modern theater. Gaulier kept a drum handy while we were onstage, banging it to cut short a performance he considered "sh-t," which was often. His goal, and greatest gift to us, was helping his students discover what he called their "inner idiot."

Gaulier introduced me to the satirical archetype of the bouffon. In his telling, the tradition dated back to 11th century France, where societal outcasts—gay people, heretics, those with deformities—would be let back into their villages once a year to put on shows viciously mocking the ruling class. It was the humor of the dispossessed. Whereas clowns were naive idiots, bouffons savagely undermined the people in power. They were doing something important: using biting and at times cruel humor to undermine systemic injustice.

Photograph by Nadav Kander for TIME

It’s what satirists have done throughout history. And along the way, some people, instead of laughing, wince—or worse, take offense. The Greek playwright Aristophanes brilliantly lampooned the militarism and demagoguery of his day. Yet because he deployed phallic jokes so obscene they would make even Ali G blush, critics like Plutarch sneered at Aristophanes’ “coarseness ... in words, vulgarity, and ribaldry.” We celebrate the Roman satirist Juvenal, but his contemporaries barely acknowledged him. Nearly two millennia later, Lenny Bruce’s four-letter comedy was branded “sick” in the pages of this magazine in 1959. Note to editors (and to Plutarch): you missed the point.

Yes, satire can offend people other than the intended targets. Like that of my bouffon predecessors, mine definitely has. As someone who has opposed bigotry and injustice throughout my life and partnered with civil rights groups, I don't recognize myself in the warped portrayals of me that I sometimes see on social media, lumped in with the bigots I lampoon.

I've always designed my characters and comedy as vehicles to expose prejudice, bias, and stupidity, though I realize not everyone sees them that way. Ali G is a white imbecile—a delusional cultural appropriator—who steals the fashion and lyrics from his favorite gangsta rap and dancehall idols, from Compton to Kingston. The joke is on him, and on the predominantly white male establishment who take him seriously enough to believe that HBO would hire the stupidest man in the world as an interview host. Like a good bouffon, he undermines that establishment—not the culture he loves and borrows from.

I admit that most of my humor is indeed juvenile. That's because satire works best not when it preaches, but rather when it lives among the laughter. Then, once you walk out of the theater or switch off the TV, it makes you think.

What makes satirical comedy so effective is what it lays bare. I'll never forget a fox-hunting rally I attended the first time I created Borat—which involved me rummaging around in the trunk of my car for two minutes, finding a hat I'd bought in Astrakhan, Russia, and sticking it on my head. "Jagshemash," I proclaimed, riffing off a Polish greeting.

I asked the English toffs, "In my country we hunt criminals—do you think we should do that here?" Shockingly, even though on camera, they said yes. A light bulb exploded in my 25-year-old brain. Real people believed this ridiculous character—and they would speak to him more freely than in any documentary.

Each of my characters has a specific mechanism to encourage people to drop their guards and show what they really believe, prejudices and all. Borat, an antisemitic journalist, exposes Jew hatred, xenophobia, sexism, and casual racism. Erran Morad, a stereotype of a tough-guy Israeli commando—“I’ve been in 14 terror attacks,” he says in my new movie *Ali G: Who Iz I?*, “and started two”—exposes Islamophobia and the ludicrous things people will do when they’re gripped by an irrational fear of “the other.”

Sacha Baron Cohen transforms into Ali G on the set of Ali G: Who Iz I?Courtesy of Michael Legato

As the titular Ali G, left, in the new movie Ali G: Who Iz I?Courtesy of Amazon MGM Studios

Ali G works on another level. He’s not extreme—he’s just extremely dumb. But his absurd questions lead powerful people to

underestimate him and answer in earnest, revealing their own biases.

Other characters highlight the problems facing our society without engaging real people at all. *The Dictator*'s Admiral General Aladeen—the cartoonish ruler of a fictional Horn of Africa nation and a mash-up of personality-cult authoritarians from Kim Jong Il to Idi Amin—warned, in 2012, how easily democracies could fall into autocracies.

Regardless of the madness, the method is the same: make the audience laugh as hard and as much as possible, while holding up a mirror to reflect back things that aren't always comfortable to see or warn of trends we'd rather look away from.

Done well, brutally honest satire can be cuttingly effective. At a time when Hollywood largely avoided anti-Nazi content, Charlie Chaplin—then one of the most famous movie stars in the world—used *The Great Dictator* to point to the destruction that Nazism would bring. Peter Sellers' sinister Dr. Strangelove showed the insanity of mutually assured destruction. Abbie Hoffman, who became a hero of mine while I researched my undergraduate thesis on civil rights—and whom I later played in *The Trial of the Chicago 7*—deployed outrageous stunts to oppose the Vietnam War.

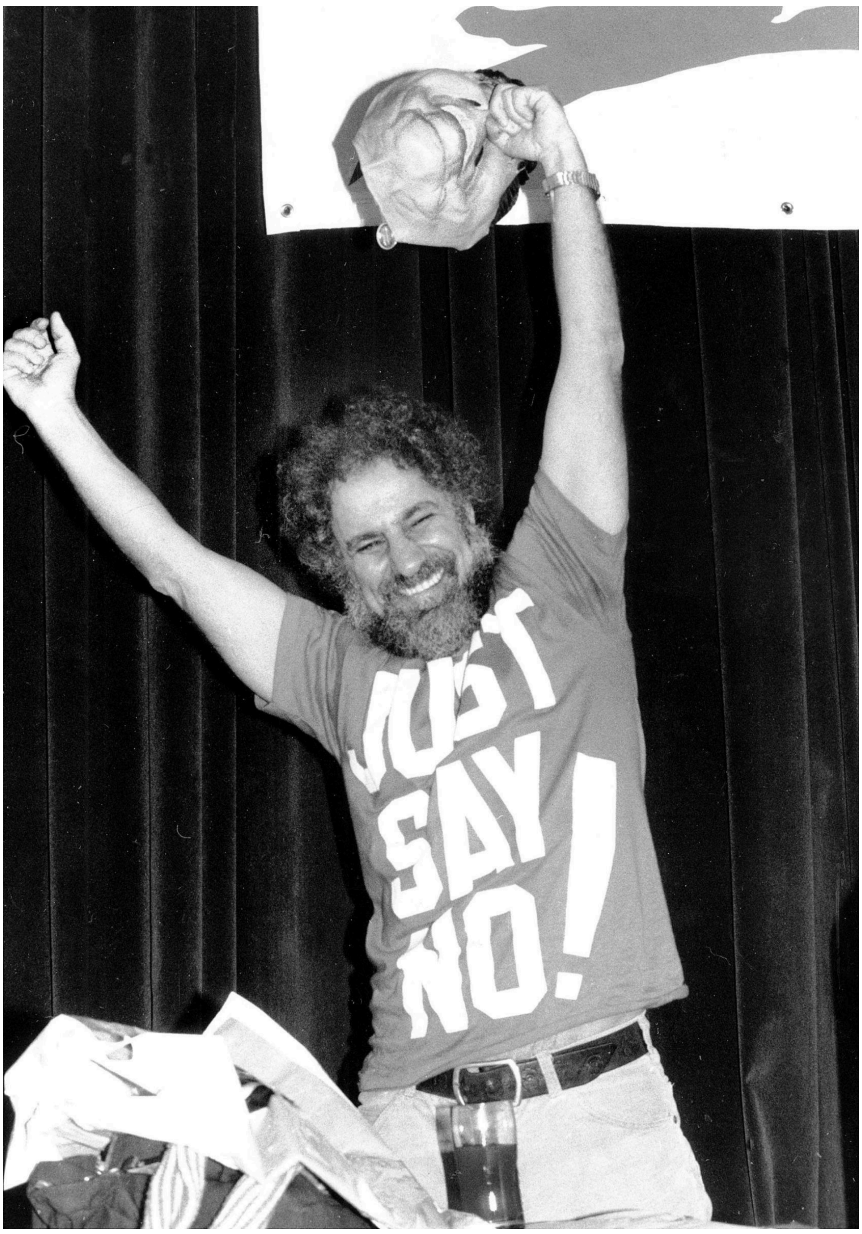
In fact, satire doesn't just needle politicians or regimes—it occasionally helps bring them down. In *Hammer & Tickle*, the historian Ben Lewis credits Soviet joke-telling with helping to topple communism, by making it impossible for even the system's own enforcers to take it seriously. Volodymyr Zelensky was a Ukrainian comedian who once pretended to play piano with his penis—a stunt Aristophanes would have loved. Yet Zelensky's TV show parodied the country's corrupt oligarchy so effectively that, just four years after *Servant of the People* premiered, he was

elected President himself. “Every joke,” George Orwell observed, “is a tiny revolution.”

Of course, comedy has its limits—more satirists in Weimar Germany could not have prevented Nazism. Still, satire—along with a free press, independent institutions, and a robust civil society—does play a role in promoting free societies.

That’s exactly what so many governments seem afraid of. In Nazi Germany, mocking Hitler could be a capital offense. Stalin sent an estimated 200,000 citizens to the gulags for making political gags. In our own time, Chinese censors have scrubbed social media of a meme comparing President Xi Jinping to Winnie the Pooh; one student who shared that and other unflattering posts got six months in prison for “picking quarrels and provoking trouble.” Last year in Tehran, the comedian Zeinab Mousavi was sentenced to six months simply for parodying an Iranian epic poem.

Even in democracies, satirists, instead of getting a laugh, sometimes face sanctions. In the U.S., Lenny Bruce and George Carlin were arrested for uttering obscenities. Because of its irreverent treatment of Christianity, *Monty Python’s Life of Brian*—the very film that introduced me to satire—was banned in half a dozen countries, and even parts of the U.K.



Abbie Hoffman holding a Ronald Reagan mask by the nose, after his keynote speech at the CMJ Music Marathon, Aug. 29, 1988. Hoffman's shirt is in reference to Nancy Reagan's campaign of saying, JUST SAY NO! to drugs, but Hoffman had modified it to saying JUST SAY NO! to drug testing.Richard Corkery—NY Daily News Archive/Getty Images

Philippe Gaulier and Bridget Brandon (Director of Drama Action Center) at their center at Rozelle Hospital, Church St. Leichhardt. Aug. 21, 1988.Philip Wayne Lock—Fairfax Media/Getty Images

Today, some believe the times have overtaken Orwell's "tiny revolutions." In an era when the U.S. President and his ilk seem impervious to shame and ridicule, is satire all but dead?

Absolutely not. In fact, I believe that satire is more important than ever. The Trump Administration's own actions show why. If ridicule is now irrelevant, why did CBS cancel Stephen Colbert's show just days after he mocked his parent company for paying Trump $16 million to settle a lawsuit? Why did Trump's chairman of the Federal Communications Commission appear to threaten ABC's broadcast license—leading ABC to briefly suspend *Jimmy*

Kimmel Live!—after Kimmel's comments about the killing of conservative activist Charlie Kirk?

Even Trump doth protest too much. Asked in 2020 about Borat outing his attorney Rudy Giuliani as a creep, Trump dredged up the time I tried to scam him as Ali G two decades earlier: "That's a phony guy and I don't find him funny."

So why does my new movie bring back that phony and unfunny guy, which some have criticized as "microwaving a relic from a generation ago?"

The fact that Ali G is outdated and problematic is the very reason I resurrected him. The world he's returned to is, in many ways, worse than the one he left 20 years ago. All the prejudices my characters are designed to expose haven't just lingered—they've metastasized. They're fueled by the greatest propaganda machine in history—social media—and now by its monstrous child, AI.

Back when I first created Borat, it took a few minutes—or a few drinks—to get people to reveal the racism that often simmered below the surface. Now, those views have gone mainstream—whether it's fans hurling slurs and abuse at Black players during the World Cup or hundreds of white nationalists marching through Washington, D.C., on July 4.

In 2004, also as Borat, I got a bar full of people to sing "Throw the Jew Down the Well." Today Jews make up just 2% of the U.S. population, yet are the targets of nearly 70% of religion-based hate crimes in America. Whatever your politics, the trend is undeniable.

In 2018, disguised as Dr. Nira Cain-N'Degeocello, an ultra-woke developer planning to build a mosque in a small town, I showed people's hostility to Muslims. One even declared, "I'm racist—

towards Muslims.” Now, right-wing U.S. Congressmen readily admit as much.

On my 2018 show *Who Is America?*, I convinced three men to host a fake quinceañera to trap undocumented immigrants. Now, stoked by far-right agitators and viral social media posts, anti-immigrant protests and riots have erupted across England and in Belfast. Meanwhile, ICE agents are running amok—terrorizing cities and, yes, detaining people at a quinceañera.

As Borat, in 2006’s Borat: Cultural Learnings of America for Make Benefit Glorious Nation of Kazakhstan.AJ Pics—Alamy

Then there’s the explosion of misogyny. Six years ago, in *Borat Subsequent Moviefilm*, a plastic surgeon cheerfully discussed giving my fictional 15-year-old daughter Tutar breast implants to appeal to important men. In today’s “manosphere,” that’s nothing compared with how Andrew Tate advises his millions of followers to treat women. Nor was overturning *Roe v. Wade* and a women’s right to control her own body apparently enough. Christian nationalists are now calling for “household voting”—effectively taking the right to vote from many women and giving it to their husbands.

Twenty years ago, Ali G would sit next to world experts spouting absurdities. Today—fed a steady diet of disinformation and conspiracy theories by social media influencers and TikTok news—

we have created an entire world where ignorance reigns and truth is inverted.

Thanks to this toxic brew of lies, conspiracies, and hate, right-wing authoritarianism is on the march. Intolerance and extremism have surged on the left as well. Political violence has increased, as has our tolerance for it. In one survey, one-fifth of Americans agreed that “true American patriots may have to resort to violence in order to save our country.”

We are once again entering an age of “virtuous” violence, where any atrocity—by racists, Jew haters, or Islamophobes, the right or the left—can be somehow justified. It is not a place any of us should want to live.

Where, then, do we go from here?

In a world where social media and AI hypercharge lies, who decides what’s considered truth? In a culture seemingly obsessed with dividing people by identity, how do we find commonality in our shared human experience?

I made this latest film for the same reason I’ve always done this work. Not only to make people laugh, but also to bring them face-to-face with the danger of fanaticism and conspiracy theories.

I’m not naive. One film won’t stamp out age-old prejudices or stop the extremism that’s fueling the slide from democracy to autocracy and mass violence. But, as satire has done since ancient times, it can help sound the alarm. It can remind people about the very real dangers of ludicrous lies—whether spread by a thin-skinned authoritarian or an extremist with an online following. With the U.S. midterm elections just weeks away, perhaps it encourages citizens to mobilize against these dangerous falsehoods—at the ballot box and beyond. Maybe it can even help shame more of our

governments into finally making our Silicon Valley overlords—unelected billionaires who decide what billions of people see and believe—liable for the lies, conspiracies, and hate on their platforms that have already gotten people killed and will likely kill many more.

Satirists can expose hypocrisy. Bouffons can shed their clothes and show that the emperor has none. But after the credits roll, it's up to all of us to decide what comes next. If our pluralistic democracies are going to survive, we need to create societies where we stop the hate and tolerate those different from us—no matter who they are, where they come from, whom they love, or how they pray. Because the only way out of this mess is to treat everyone with what Ali G has always preached: Respect.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/20/sacha-baron-cohen-on-satire/

U.S.

- **Cornell Halts Fraternity Parties After Jane Doe’s Lawsuit**
  In addition to suspending social events at frat houses, the university will allow state police to investigate reported sexual assaults on campus.
- **Your Questions About Voting in the 2026 Midterm Elections, Answered**
  From using mail-in ballots to finding your polling place, here’s everything you need to know.

U.S. | Higher Education

Cornell Halts Fraternity Parties After Jane Doe's Lawsuit

Cornell University said on Tuesday that it is barring fraternity houses from hosting parties for the remainder of the academic year in an effort "to strengthen campus safety" after the school faced widespread backlash over its handling of an alleged gang rape by fraternity members in 2024.

Cornell President Michael I. Kotlikoff announced the news in a letter addressed to the campus community, which said that the ban will be effective immediately. He also outlined ways that the university would work to improve how it handles allegations of sexual assault in the future. In addition to strengthening campus safety, he addressed the need to provide better support to survivors—which involves allowing the New York State Police to independently investigate sexual assault allegations—and change the social culture at the university.

Cornell did not respond to questions about how the new measures would be implemented or tracked, but referred TIME to its FAQ page regarding the 2024 incident.

The announcement comes about a month after a woman, known as Jane Doe, filed a civil lawsuit against several entities, including Cornell, the Chi Phi fraternity, and seven members of Chi Phi that she alleges sexually assaulted her in 2024. The case has made national headlines, and many people have criticized how Cornell and local authorities handled the incident. Hundreds of students and staff members held a protest on campus earlier this month,

with some calling for Kotlikoff to resign and others chanting phrases like “Ban the frats!”

Read More: *After the Cornell Case, Should Colleges Ban Fraternities?*

In his letter on Tuesday, Kotlikoff addressed the backlash, saying that his conversations with various members of the campus community and the campus protests “have underscored my deep conviction that we must do better: that the time for meaningful and lasting change at Cornell, and at campuses across the country, is now.”

“I am deeply sorry for the harm Jane Doe suffered in 2024, and appalled that this act of sexual violence occurred within our Cornell community,” Kotlikoff said. “It is clear that women on our campus continue to question whether they are safe. We must meet this moment by acknowledging where we have fallen short and taking meaningful action.”

Amid mounting pressure, Cornell’s Board of Trustees announced earlier this month that Sally Yates, a former acting U.S. attorney general, will lead an independent review into how the school handled the case. Kotlikoff also addressed the review in his letter, but said “it is clear that we cannot wait for these findings to take action.” Cooperation with the New York State Police would coincide with the independent review; Kotlikoff said in his letter that investigators will interview survivors who decide to pursue criminal charges and “prepare comprehensive investigative summaries for the appropriate law enforcement agency.”

Kotlikoff said that Interfraternity Council houses will be barred from holding parties and social events, which “will provide time for a thorough review of fraternity life at Cornell to determine whether and how it can safely continue.” He added that the university will have a “zero tolerance” policy if fraternities violate

the new rule, and that any fraternity that hosts “an in-house party or social event will receive an immediate emergency suspension.” Cornell has previously said that the Chi Phi fraternity on campus "was closed in 2024 and remains barred from campus."

Other measures that Kotlikoff announced include strengthening support for survivors, such as by adding staffers to the Cornell Office of Civil Rights, and “changing the social culture at Cornell” through several initiatives, such as enhancing “existing education and programming to address the bystander effect.”

“These are first steps toward systemic change on our campus,” Kotlikoff said. “We will take all necessary steps to address the conditions that led to Jane Doe’s experiences, and those of other survivors. Cornell must be a place where safety is not an open question.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/13/cornell-halts-fraternity-parties-after-jane-doe-s-lawsuit/

U.S. | Voting

Your Questions About Voting in the 2026 Midterm Elections, Answered

A sticker is presented to voters after they submit their ballot.Jeff Taylor—The Winchester Star via AP

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Narrated by TIME AI.

Election Day is Nov. 3, 2026, in the United States. Held midway through each four-year presidential term, midterm elections give voters a chance to choose local representatives, weigh in on state issues, and determine which party controls Congress.

Read More: *Congress Is Headed for a Massive Turnover*

This year's midterms will take place among unique challenges to the democratic process itself.

The Trump Administration has attempted to restrict mail-in voting and gather voter data from several states. There have also been concerns raised about the presence of federal agents at polling

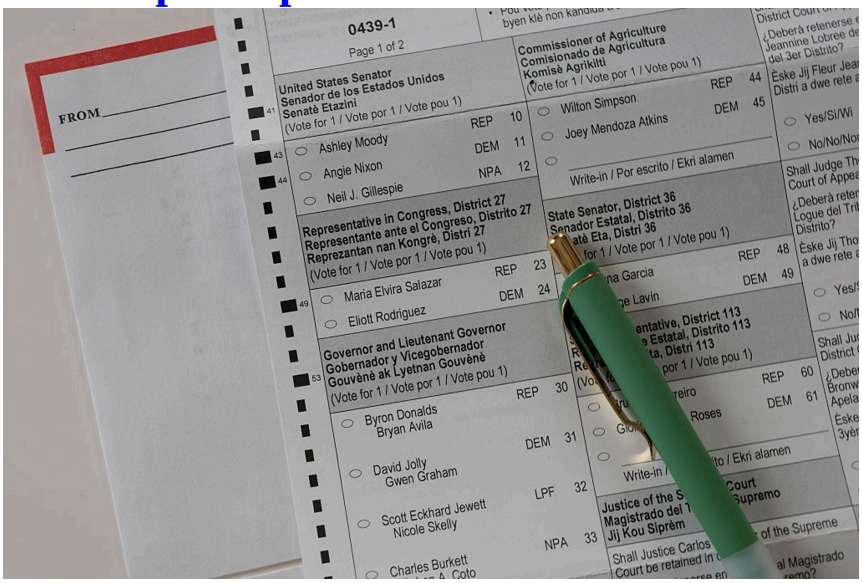
stations, which President Donald Trump has not categorically ruled out.

The TIME staff has put together answers to some of your most pressing questions about the midterm elections in our 2026 Voting Guide.

Questions:

- **What's on my ballot?**
- **Who can register to vote?**
- **How can I check my voter registration status?**
- **When is the deadline to register to vote?**
- **What documents do I need to register to vote?**
- **Can I vote if my voter registration is inactive?**
- **How can I update my registration (change of name, address, party enrollment)?**
- **How do I vote early—and what are the benefits of early voting?**
- **How do I request an absentee ballot?**
- **What's the difference between absentee voting and vote-by-mail?**
- **How do I know if my mail-in ballot arrived and was counted?**
- **What if there’s an issue with my mail-in ballot? Can I fix it?**
- **Do I need to bring my ID to vote?**
- **What’s the best time to vote to avoid long lines?**
- **Can I bring my kids or dog to the polls?**
- **What counts as voter intimidation?**
- **What should I do if someone tries to stop me from voting?**
- **What if there are protests at my polling site?**
- **Can I use my phone to record acts of voter intimidation?**

- **What do I do if I see ICE or federal agents at the polls?**
- **How late are polls open?**



Joe Raedle—Getty Images

Answers:

What's on my ballot?

Unlike presidential election years, there is no candidate or issue that appears on every ballot across the U.S. in 2026.

Instead, the ballots in every state will vary—and many will be different from county to county, as well. There are U.S. Senate races in 35 states, and gubernatorial elections in 36 states. All 435 seats in the U.S. House of Representatives are up for election, as they are every two years. There will also be downballot races for positions in the state legislature.

In four states—Idaho, Missouri, Nevada, and Virginia—voters will be deciding on ballot measures concerning abortion rights. Voters in six states, including Alaska and Arizona, will decide on whether to add or strengthen citizenship requirements for voting in state and local elections.

There are multiple ways for voters to request a sample ballot so they can see both what propositions will be on their state ballot and what local, state, and federal positions will appear on their ballot. Vote.org and Ballotpedia both have sample ballot lookup tools.

Many official websites—including those in Minnesota, Wisconsin, and New York City—also have their own "What's On My Ballot" pages, which allow voters to enter their address and look up a sample ballot. *—Rebecca Schneid*

Who can register to vote?

People can register to vote in federal elections if they are a U.S. citizen and meet their state's eligibility and registration requirements. Voters generally must be 18 years old on or before Election Day, although almost every state allows people to register before their birthday if they will be 18 by Election Day. North Dakota does not require voter registration.

Voters must also meet their state's residency requirements, but people who are experiencing homelessness or who are between homes also are able to vote. Depending on state law, they may need identification. They can generally use a shelter, religious center, or P.O. box as a mailing address and identify the place where they live or sleep as their residential address.

Non-citizens, including permanent legal residents, can vote in *some* local elections but cannot vote in federal or state elections.

In some states, people who were convicted of a felony or are currently incarcerated are also restricted from voting. Check this federal voter guide for voting after a felony conviction to see what rules exist in your state. *—Rebecca Schneid*

How can I check my voter registration status?

You can check if you're registered to vote by going to the National Association of Secretaries of State website. After you choose your state in the dropdown menu, you'll be sent to the state's election website. The information required to check if your voter registration is active varies by state, but most will ask for information like your name, date of birth, and address.

If you're not already registered to vote, you may be able to register online, by mail, or in person, depending on your state. Check your state's requirements and registration deadline before submitting an application. —*Chantelle Lee*

When is the deadline to register to vote?

The deadline to register to vote varies by state. Check the U.S. Vote Foundation's website to find your state's deadline. —*Chantelle Lee*

What documents do I need to register to vote?

In most cases, you will need a driver's license or state identification card—or information from one—to register to vote. If you don't have either, your state may accept other documentation, such as a utility bill or bank statement. Requirements vary by state, so check with your state election office to find out what information and documents you will need. —*Anna Gordon*

Can I vote if my voter registration is inactive?

Your registration may be marked inactive if election officials believe you have moved and you do not respond to a notice asking you to confirm your address. Inactive voters generally remain registered and can still vote, although they may have to confirm their address or follow other state-specific procedures at the polls.

Voters can contact their state or local election office to learn how to restore their registration to active status and what identification or documentation may be required. *—T. Michelle Murphy*

How can I update my registration (change of name, address, party enrollment)?

Voters in states that record party affiliation may change it through their state's election office. However, party enrollment is not necessary to vote in the midterm elections in November, and party affiliation does not limit you to candidates from that party in a general election. Party affiliation may affect which primary a voter can participate in, depending on state law.

To change a name or address, voters generally follow the same process used to register to vote. They can use the national Election Assistance Commission map, click their state, and see how each state prefers updates to voter registration.

Voters can also submit a National Mail Voter Registration Form, which can be used to re-register to vote in every state except North Dakota, New Hampshire, and Wyoming, and it is available in 21 languages. *—Rebecca Schneid*

Ellen Schmidt—AP

How do I vote early—and what are the benefits of early voting?

People who want to avoid long lines and those who might not have time to go to their polling location on Election Day may wish to take advantage of early voting. Early voting began in four states Sept. 18 and will expand to the rest throughout October.

As of 2026, 47 states and Washington, D.C., allow any voter to vote early in person. Alabama, Mississippi, and New Hampshire require an eligible excuse.

The process for early voting differs depending on your state. You can find the specific times and rules for early voting in your state at USA.gov. *—Chantelle Lee*

How do I request an absentee ballot?

If you live in the U.S., you can request an absentee ballot by visiting the National Association of Secretaries of State website and selecting your state from the dropdown menu. Because eligibility requirements, deadlines, and application procedures vary by state, be sure to follow the instructions provided by local election officials.

U.S. citizens living outside the country, absent members of the Uniformed Services or Merchant Marine, and their eligible family members can register to vote and request an absentee ballot through the Federal Voting Assistance Program. They can do so by completing a Federal Post Card Application, or FPCA, using the U.S. address that establishes their voting residence. For overseas citizens, this is generally the last place they lived before leaving the country; for military voters, it is generally their address in their state of legal residence. The completed form must be signed and

returned to the appropriate election office in accordance with that state's submission requirements. *—Rebecca Schneid*

What's the difference between absentee voting and vote-by-mail?

Absentee voting and vote-by-mail both allow voters to cast ballots without visiting a polling site. This can be done by returning a ballot by mail, at a dropbox, or in person, depending on state law. The terms vary by state, but a key difference is often whether voters must request a ballot or receive one automatically.

In states where vote-by-mail exists, all active registered voters are automatically delivered a vote-by-mail ballot to their registered address. Eight states—California, Colorado, Hawaii, Nevada, Oregon, Utah, Vermont, and Washington—conduct elections this way.

In states without universal vote-by-mail programs, individuals must request absentee ballots ahead of time. There are often deadlines and rules that voters must meet in order to participate in the program, and some states may require individuals to have an excuse in order to be eligible for an absentee ballot. *—Anna Gordon*

David Paul Morris—Bloomberg via Getty Images

How do I know if my mail-in ballot arrived and was counted?

Most states offer some form of online ballot tracking, according to Vote.org. Illinois, Missouri, and Wyoming do not have statewide online mail-ballot trackers, although tracking may be available in some local jurisdictions.

Each state's tracker is a little different, but they generally allow you to log in with your voter registration information to see if your ballot has been received yet. If your jurisdiction doesn't offer online tracking, contact your local election office to ask whether your ballot was received and accepted for counting. —*Anisha Kohli*

What if there's an issue with my mail-in ballot? Can I fix it?

If election officials identify a problem with your ballot, they may notify you and give you an opportunity to fix—or "cure"—it, depending on your state and the type of problem.

"The election official who is reviewing ballots will tell you what information you need to provide to make that cure, such as signing a new ballot envelope or providing a copy of your ID," according to Nick Morrow, a communications and design director at Vote.org. Be sure to complete the process by the deadline set by your state.

The criteria for rejection varies by state, but to prevent your ballot from being rejected, do your best to ensure it's returned in good condition and early. A missing or unverifiable signature can cause your ballot to be rejected. —*Simmone Shah*

David Jennings—Digital First Media/Boulder Daily Camera via Getty Images

Do I need to bring my ID to vote?

As of 2026, 36 states require you to show some form of identification before you can legally cast your ballot. But the forms of identification that are acceptable vary by state; they may include a driver's license, passport, voter registration confirmation, utility bill, or bank statement. You can check your local requirements on USA.gov.

If you do not have the requested identification, you may still be able to vote by signing a statement confirming your identity or casting a provisional ballot. In some states, you must provide acceptable identification after Election Day in order for your ballot to be counted. Federal law also requires certain first-time voters who registered by mail to provide identification if their identity was not verified during registration. *—T. Michelle Murphy*

What's the best time to vote to avoid long lines?

Long lines can be a strong deterrent to voting, especially for Black and Latino voters, who on average have experienced longer waits

than white voters, according to a June 2020 report by the Brennan Center for Justice.

Since polling hours and conditions vary by county, and even within a county, wait times can be unpredictable. But early mornings and after-work hours tend to be the busiest times.

Additionally, lines tend to be longer on Election Day than they are during early voting periods, which do not demonstrate any consistent high-traffic time slots.

However, there is no universally confirmed “least busy” time to vote. —*Solcyre Burga*

Can I bring my kids or dog to the polls?

Voters generally may bring children with them to the polling place, although rules about their ages, how many children may accompany a voter, and whether they may enter the voting booth vary. To learn about the guidelines at your polling site, contact your local election office.

Dogs, however, are a different story. Voters are allowed to bring certified service animals to voting sites, but accommodations for pets and emotional support animals vary by location. It is best to presume they are not allowed but to look into the specific guidelines for your polling location. —*Rebecca Schneid*
Read More: ***Why I Bring My Kids to Vote with Me***

Charlie Neibergall—Getty Images

What counts as voter intimidation?

Voter intimidation involves threats, coercion, or other conduct that unlawfully interferes with someone's ability to vote freely.

All acts of voter intimidation are prohibited across the U.S. There are sweeping federal protections—wherein acts of intimidation may result in a fine, imprisonment, or both—but states may also have their own laws restricting it. Attempted intimidation is also prohibited, which means that acts of intimidation are illegal even if they do not ultimately prevent someone from voting.

These laws do not just protect voters on Election Day. They also cover registration periods and early voting.

The ACLU stresses that acts of voter intimidation are rare, and it is unlikely that most voters will encounter it. However, it recommends that individuals be aware of their rights, what constitutes intimidation, and what to do in the event that it does occur.

Acts of voter intimidation could include, but are not limited to:

- Falsely presenting oneself as an election official
- Displaying false or misleading signs about how to vote or voting penalties
- Blocking access to a polling site or interfering with the act of casting a vote
- Spreading false information about a person's rights or voting requirements (such as falsely stating that a photo ID is required in a state where it is not needed to vote)
- Aggressively questioning voters about their political persuasion or eligibility to vote
- Harassing or threatening voters in a manner that interferes with their right to vote.

If you witness or encounter such conduct, you should immediately notify poll workers and local election officials. If there is violence or immediate danger, call 911.

You may wish to document suspected intimidation by noting what happened, who was involved, and when and where it occurred. Before taking photos or recording video or audio, check the rules at your polling location. Recording voters can itself constitute intimidation, depending on the circumstances.

You can also call the Election Protection hotline at 866-OUR-VOTE. The same service is also available for non-English voters. Spanish speakers can call 888-VE-Y-VOTA. Many Asian language speakers can find assistance in their native language at 888-API-VOTE. Arabic speakers can call 844-YALLA-US. —*T. Michelle Murphy*

What should I do if someone tries to stop me from voting?

Voter intimidation is illegal and relatively rare. If someone tries to stop you from voting, you should alert nearby poll workers and

your local election officials, who can determine if law enforcement should be involved, says Sean Morales-Doyle, the senior director of the Brennan Center for Justice's Voting Rights and Election Program. You should also contact the nonpartisan Election Protection hotline for assistance at 866-OUR-VOTE.

The same service is also available for non-English voters. Spanish speakers can call 888-VE-Y-VOTA. Most Asian language speakers can find assistance in their native language at 888-API-VOTE. Arabic speakers can call 844-YALLA-US.

If you feel like you're in danger, call 911. —*Mariah Espada*

What if there are protests at my polling site?

Every state has some form of restriction on electioneering—campaigning for or against candidates, political parties, or ballot measures—in or near a polling site. Some restrict putting up campaign signs. Others also bar voters and volunteers from wearing certain campaign-related clothing. This also includes various forms of protesting.

In particular, laws restrict how close people engaging in electioneering can be to a polling place. The distance and activities covered vary by state; the restrictions do not necessarily apply to every form of protest.

Regardless of their distance from the polling place, protesters may not intimidate voters or unlawfully interfere with their access to voting. Blocking the entrance or attempting to turn away voters can constitute voter intimidation or interference. If you witness or encounter such conduct, you should immediately notify poll workers and local election officials.

You can also call the Election Protection hotline at 866-OUR-VOTE. The same service is also available for non-English voters.

Spanish speakers can call 888-VE-Y-VOTA. Most Asian language speakers can find assistance in their native language at 888-API-VOTE. Arabic speakers can call 844-YALLA-US.

If there is violence or immediate danger, call 911. *—T. Michelle Murphy*

Can I use my phone to record acts of attempted voter intimidation?

Voter intimidation is illegal. If you are experiencing intimidation or harassment, or if you witness it happening to someone else, you should inform poll workers and local election officials about the situation as soon as possible.

You may feel compelled to document what's happening. But before you pull out your phone, you should confirm whether recording is legal at your polling place. The laws vary by state.

In Arizona, for instance, state law bars people from taking photos or videos within 75 feet of a voting location. Other states don't have laws that expressly ban people from recording at a polling place; however, you should be aware that photography, videotaping, and audio recording can themselves be construed as a form of voter intimidation. *—Chantelle Lee*

What do I do if I see ICE or federal agents at the polls?

The Trump Administration has not said that immigration enforcement officers would be at the polls this November, but it also has not ruled out the possibility. When asked in May whether he would deploy federal agents on Election Day, Trump told

reporters that he would do “anything necessary” to make sure the U.S. has “honest” elections.

The Department of Homeland Security (DHS) has said that Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) is not planning operations targeting polling locations, while leaving open the possibility of enforcement in the event of a public safety threat. In September, DHS Secretary Markwayne Mullin confirmed that agents could serve warrants at polling places.

Read More: *ICE Does Not Belong at the Polls*

Gen. Dan Caine, Chair of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, said Aug. 31 that there are no plans to station military personnel or the National Guard at polling sites.
For voters, it’s important to know that federal interference at the polls is against the law. The law prohibits federal officials from stationing troops or armed personnel at polling places, except when necessary to repel armed enemies of the United States. Voter intimidation is also, separately, prohibited and should be reported.

If you see any federal agents at the polls, the best move is to contact the election protection hotline at 1-866-OUR-VOTE. This hotline has other language options, including 1-888-VE-Y-VOTA for Spanish, 1-888-API-VOTE for several Asian languages, and 1-844-YALLA-US for Arabic.

The American Civil Liberties Union suggests that voters look up the contact information for their local election officials here and report intimidation if it occurs before or on Election Day. — *Rebecca Schneid*

How late are polls open?

Polling hours vary state by state—sometimes even county by county. For example, poll closing times vary in North Dakota and

New Hampshire; in such instances, you can utilize search functions on each state's respective website.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/30/your-questions-about-voting-in-the-2026-midterm-elections-answered/

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World | Israel

Israel's Choice

An election campaign banner featuring Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu hangs on a store ahead of Israel's general election in Tel Aviv, Israel, Monday, Oct. 12, 2026.Oded Balilty—AP

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Narrated by TIME AI.

The Israeli settlement of Neve Daniel sits south of Jerusalem, atop one of the highest ridges in the West Bank, nearly 1,000 meters above sea level. The view to the east stretches to the mountains of Jordan, and to the west across the Mediterranean coastal plain—where most Israelis live. But the tranquility of the landscape belies the political fervor animating the Oct. 27 election, a contest with stakes as great as any in the 78-year history of the world's only Jewish state. When I ask three residents what will ultimately determine their votes, one responds with particular ferocity.

"Seven hundred trucks were delivered to Hamas today by Israel," says Barak Moore, who has lived in Neve Daniel for 14 years. He's referring to commercial goods and international aid entering the

Gaza Strip. “We’re paying a terrorist organization that committed the greatest atrocity against the Jewish people since Auschwitz.”

While much of the world has come to define Israel by its military actions in Gaza since Oct. 7, 2023, Moore’s views reflect the passions coursing through a society still traumatized by that day. Israelis tend to be less preoccupied by the nearly 75,000 Palestinian fatalities in Gaza since the war began, than by the 1,200 people killed in Israel and 251 hostages taken by Hamas—the women subjected to sexual violence, the children shot at point-blank range, the families burned alive in their homes. In a country so small and intimately connected, scarcely anyone was untouched by events that shattered the assumptions of a people whose nation was founded to give Jews a safe haven in their ancestral homeland.

Both the Hamas massacre and the wars that followed loom over a vote shaping up not only as a referendum on Benjamin Netanyahu, but also the nature of the country that, as Israel’s longest serving prime minister, he has done so much to shape.

Arrayed against Netanyahu is a fractured field of challengers. There is Gadi Eisenkot, the former military chief whose reputation for honesty, sobriety, and competence contrasts with Netanyahu’s polarizing leadership; Naftali Bennett, the right-wing former prime minister seeking a comeback; Yair Lapid, the centrist former premier who has spent years trying to dislodge Netanyahu; and Avigdor Lieberman, the hawkish secular nationalist who has become one of Netanyahu’s fiercest adversaries.

Also on the ballot: Itamar Ben-Gvir and Bezalel Smotrich, far-right extremists whose parties made possible Netanyahu’s current coalition, and whose ambitions to annex the West Bank and resettle Gaza constrain his room to maneuver while damaging Israel’s standing abroad. The next government will either push Israel further down the path of religious nationalism, permanent conflict,

and international isolation—or toward a new generation of leadership.

According to the polls, Netanyahu's strongest challenger is Eisenkot, a soft-spoken, heavyset career soldier running as a centrist. His son, Gal, was killed fighting Hamas in Gaza, and one of his nephews also died in the war. Eisenkot is campaigning on a promise to restore public trust in government, rebuild Israel's security, and heal the divisions that have fractured the country. "This election is about the identity of Israel," Eisenkot told TIME in an interview on Oct. 20. "What will be Israel two weeks from now, 10 years from now, 20 years from now? This is the main question."

Gadi Eisenkot walks past memorial displays honoring victims at the Nova music festival site as Israel marks the third anniversary of the Oct. 7th 2023 attacks.Erik Marmor—Getty Images

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Three years after Netanyahu's political obituary was being written, pre-election polls show him running in a dead heat. On the eve of the vote, the nation is suffused with a sense of uncertainty; political analysts say almost anything can happen. Netanyahu and Eisenkot could form a unity government. Netanyahu could cobble together another right-wing coalition, dragging Israel further right. Eisenkot could join forces with Bennett, Lapid, and the Arab parties (20% of Israeli citizens are Palestinian) to oust Netanyahu,

producing the closest thing Israel could muster to a center-left government. Or perhaps no bloc will manage to pull together the 61 Knesset seats needed for a majority, plunging Israel into another round of elections and a reprise of the paralysis that produced five contests between 2019 and 2022.

“The most probable scenarios currently are either there will be some sort of unity government, which again is very complicated politically because all of the opposition parties swear they don’t want it under Netanyahu, and I don’t see how Netanyahu is going to sit under them,” says Nimrod Nor, an expert on Israeli politics at Hebrew University. “The other is we’re going to have another election after this one.”

According to two sources familiar with Netanyahu’s thinking, he would prefer to form a unity government with Eisenkot. One reason is legacy. He believes such an alliance offers his best chance to transcend the worst security failure in the nation’s history, and to be remembered not only as the leader who emerged from the slaughter of Oct. 7 to decimate Hamas in Gaza and Hezbollah in Lebanon and persuade an American president to wage war against Iran, but also as the statesman who helped to reconcile a divided nation.

The other reason, the sources say, is personal. Netanyahu has little desire to form another right-wing coalition that would leave him beholden to the radical and uncompromising parties led by Ben-Gvir and Smotrich, both of which he brought into government four years ago to reclaim power. “He thought that he could control Ben-Gvir,” one Netanyahu aide says. “Now he knows that he can’t.”

That is precisely what the Israeli right fears he’s thinking, and what brought me to Neve Daniel. The settlement of capacious red-tiled homes is just across the Green Line that defined Israel’s borders before the Six-Day War of 1967. It was built on land that was a Jewish farm even before Israel was founded in the crucible of the

1948 war. Settler violence against Palestinians has risen sharply during Netanyahu's tenure, but the militant settlers who make headlines by terrorizing their Palestinian neighbors tend to live on hilltops deeper into the West Bank than this.

But few, if any, of the 700,000 Israelis who live in settlements are leftist. Many regard Netanyahu as a cynical opportunist—a political chameleon who parrots their convictions but will do whatever it takes to survive. Among his many heresies, they say, is a long history of accommodating American presidents: signing the Wye River Memorandum under Bill Clinton to advance the Oslo peace process that aimed to create a Palestinian state; voting for the disengagement from Gaza under Ariel Sharon and George W. Bush; endorsing, at least rhetorically, a two-state solution and imposing a moratorium on settlement construction under Barack Obama; and, under Donald Trump, accepting a ceasefire and hostage-exchange agreement to end the war in Gaza.

Three people in Neve Daniel offer a revealing glimpse of the forces pulling Netanyahu rightward. Each plans to vote for a different party, but they all share an overriding objective: a right-wing government with Netanyahu at its center, constrained by allies who will keep him from drifting toward the middle.

Barak Moore is supporting Zehut, a libertarian nationalist party founded in 2015, whose eclectic platform combines tax cuts, the dismantling of monopolies, and cannabis legalization with an uncompromising vision of Israeli sovereignty and the removal of Palestinians from Gaza. It is something of a right-wing hipster party, blending free-market economics with religious nationalism.

Avi Abelow, 52, an activist who runs the website Pulse of Israel, is voting for Netanyahu's Likud Party. His complaint is not that the prime minister has gone too far in Gaza, but rather that he has not gone far enough, hamstrung by a security establishment and governing coalition insufficiently committed to the nationalist

cause. “We should have conquered all of Gaza and made sure it’s Jewish again,” he says.

The youngest of the three, Hershey Kellner, is a 19-year-old Orthodox Jew who moved to Israel from New Jersey just months before Oct. 7. He is supporting Otzma Yehudit, the far-right party led by Ben-Gvir, whose confrontational politics and open contempt for established norms have made him a hero to some of Israel’s most fervent ideologues. Helner admires Ben-Gvir’s push to expand civilian gun ownership, permit Jewish prayer on the Temple Mount, and introduce the death penalty for terrorists.

To explain his thinking, Kellner invokes one of the most consequential decisions in recent Israeli history: the 2011 deal that freed the Israeli soldier Gilad Shalit in exchange for more than 1,000 Palestinian prisoners. Among them was Yahya Sinwar, who would go on to mastermind the Oct. 7 massacre. Helner believes that sparing Sinwar’s life was a catastrophic mistake. “If you hanged him or put a bullet in the back of his head, not sure how the world would be now,” he says, “but it would definitely be better.”

For three years, Israel has been a nation at war, not only with its enemies but with itself. The extraordinary solidarity that followed Oct. 7 has given way to recriminations and ideological divisions, intensified by the trauma of war, the anguish of the hostage crisis, the pain of deepening antisemitism worldwide, and the unresolved question of who bears responsibility for such a stunning security lapse. Though Israel rejects the charge, critics accuse the country of committing a genocide in Gaza, where the dead include both uncounted Hamas fighters and 20,000 children—and of countenancing a thuggish brand of ethnic cleansing in the West Bank. On Oct. 16, masked settlers were filmed attacking Palestinians and European diplomats in the West Bank, and injuring a Washington *Post* photojournalist.

Smoke rises above Gaza after and Israeli air strike on Sept. 8, 2026.Moiz Salhi—Anadolu/Getty Images

The fault lines run through nearly every aspect of Israeli life. Secular and religious. Liberals and nationalists. Those obliged to serve in the military and the ultra-Orthodox who are not. Those who believe Israel must reach an accommodation with the Palestinians and those who want permanent Israeli control over the West Bank and Gaza. And, not least, those who regard Netanyahu as the indispensable guarantor of Jewish security and those who see him as the principal threat to the country's democratic character and reputation abroad.

The fear increasingly voiced across Israel's political and cultural establishment is that another Netanyahu victory could push those divisions toward a societal rupture. After Netanyahu's coalition moved in early 2023 to restrict the power of the Supreme Court, the prospect of another government dependent on religious and ultra-nationalist parties has raised the specter of an exodus of young Israelis, who see the country's liberal and democratic traditions slipping away. In a recent survey by the Agam Institute, an Israeli research firm, and the Hebrew University of Jerusalem, 59% of Israelis said they believe internal threats are greater than external ones, while 64% said they were considering leaving Israel, citing insecurity, living costs, and political instability. In a nation of

roughly 10 million, even the departure of tens of thousands of highly educated citizens could have consequences far beyond their numbers, draining the country of the talent and investment on which its economic and military strength depends.

There is a deeper irony. Israel was founded as a refuge, a place where a people long subjected to persecution and exile could finally determine their own destiny. Some Israelis now contemplate leaving, not because they have lost faith in the necessity of a Jewish state, but because they fear the political direction of the state created to provide one.

For those contemplating a future abroad, there is an unsettling question: Where, exactly, would they go? Antisemitism has surged across much of the world, with 2025 marking the deadliest year for Jews in the diaspora in more than three decades, according to Tel Aviv University. Israel has become increasingly isolated, condemned in international forums, denounced in the streets of European capitals, and regarded by many critics as a pariah state. The result is a profound paradox: Israelis who fear for their country's future wonder whether they would be any safer, or more welcome, anywhere else.

It is this siege mentality, the sense of a small nation standing alone against a hostile world, that Netanyahu is counting on to sustain his political survival. He has spent much of his career presenting himself as a leader hardened by history, experienced in diplomacy, and ruthless in the exercise of power. His message: Whatever Israelis think of him personally, whatever blame they assign him for Oct. 7, the world is too dangerous to entrust their security to anyone else.

The chasm between how Israelis see themselves and how much of the outside world sees them has rarely seemed wider. In the new documentary *NAZA*, Israeli filmmakers draw on the anonymous testimony of 24 soldiers and intelligence officers to expose what

they describe as the military's systematic use of artificial intelligence to identify Hamas targets in Gaza, even when commanders knew that bombing them would kill women and children. Inside Israel, meanwhile, the fifth season of *Fauda*, the country's enormously popular television thriller, recreates the atrocities of Oct. 7 in harrowing detail, immersing viewers once again in the terror, grief, and vulnerability of that day.

One production focuses on the suffering Israel inflicted, the other on the suffering Israelis endured. Together, they illuminate the competing narratives of a war that has left Israel increasingly estranged from the world, and many Israelis feeling more besieged than ever. Indications from polls and analysts are that even after voters have their say, no one bloc will have mustered a legislative majority. At that point the leading vote-getter will have weeks to try to gather a coalition, a test of the kind of political leadership at which Netanyahu has long excelled.

For nearly three decades, Netanyahu has been the dominant figure in Israeli public life, his political fortunes rising and falling with the country's anxieties and ambitions. He has survived scandals, indictments, electoral defeats, and repeated attempts to engineer his ouster. The question is whether a political system he has spent so long mastering can produce a future that no longer revolves around him.

In a country not yet 80 years old, many are ready to chart a new era. "I think that Eisenkot is the one," says Livna Savir, 72, at a rally for the challenger on a basketball court in Kibbutz Netzer Sereni, outside of Tel Aviv. "It's a change of direction." With her children living in the U.S., she laments the impacts of the last three years on a once unified group: "What happened now in our country —it's not good for the family."

World | France

How French Police 'Lost Control' of Escalating Protests

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Narrated by TIME AI.

France’s Interior Minister Laurent Nuñez on Monday admitted that police “lost control” in some cities over the weekend as violent protests erupted across the country, while French President Emmanuel Macron called for a review of the police response to the rioting and looting.

Nuñez said there had been a "lack of anticipation" ahead of the demonstrations on Saturday and acknowledged that policing numbers had fallen short in some areas as hundreds of thousands took to the streets to protest over, what they say are, underfunded public services and rising cost-of-living pressures. The demonstrations followed weeks of student protests that had also seen some violence.

In the wake of the chaotic scenes, Nuñez offered his resignation to Macron because he "felt responsible” for how things unfolded. Macron refused to accept it, due to “the need for a continuous command of the police,” the Élysée Palace told TIME. Instead, Macron has called for the Interior Ministry to “take all necessary steps to ensure transparency over planning and intelligence failures” and to put an end to the barricades and looting.

As France aims to regain full control of its streets, French Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu has extended local mayors the power to

enforce “partial curfews,” in an effort to protect businesses and people. "My determination to restore order is absolute," Lecornu told reporters, emphasizing that localized curfews were preferred over a national enforcement at this time. Paris authorities have since issued overnight curfews in two areas of the capital. The Interior Ministry reported that around 550,000 people had taken to the streets on Saturday. A French trade union put the number at over 800,000. Nuñez on Sunday said that more than 2,000 people had been arrested and over 600 police officers and firefighters injured. In Paris, at least 300 businesses were vandalised, Dominique Restino, the head of the Paris chamber of commerce, told BFM television.

Clashes occur between protesters throwing projectiles and police responding with tear gas during a demonstration against the high cost of living in Paris, France, on Oct. 17, 2026Jerome Gilles—NurPhoto/Getty Images

Alongside the violence in the capital, what started out as peaceful protests in Marseille and Lyon also turned violent as rioters descended. Authorities in Marseille on Monday imposed a temporary ban on public gatherings and demonstrations. French unions have already called for a new round of strikes and marches on Nov. 5.

Various buildings and official monuments have been targeted across the country.

A historic town hall in the French city of Limoges was damaged in what appeared to be an arson attack on Saturday. One of the main tourist offices in the city of Lyon was set ablaze. In Bordeaux, the prefect's residence was attacked, according to local authorities.

Macron condemned the "unbridled violence" as he addressed the nation Sunday evening. “Those who looted will have to pay for the damage, and those who sought to bring down the Republic will be held accountable,” he vowed in a televised speech.

Smoke rises from the bar 'La Barrique' on the sidelines of a demonstration against the "high cost of living," in Paris on Oct. 17, 2026Kiran Ridley—AFP/Getty Images

Isa Obradovich, a French-Peruvian American artist living in Paris, has participated in a number of protests since the movement went nationwide in early October. The 22-year-old says the demonstrations have become increasingly charged amid escalating clashes between protesters and police.

“I had to walk through clouds of tear gas to get home and clouds of smoke from fires,” she says of her journey home from the protests this weekend.

Obradovich notes the property damage in her own neighborhood, sharing that some of the stores she regularly visits were impacted by the protests.

“You can also see that there has been more property damage. [Some] grocery stores in my neighborhood were closed yesterday. One of them because they had boarded up the walls, and the other one because the windows of the storefront had been smashed and all the stuff inside had been ruined. I walked past as shop owners and employees were standing there looking at the devastation,” she says.

The Federation of Trade and Retail told TIME that “nearly 3,000 shops and businesses of all sizes across France have been affected by the violence over the weekend.” The French government has said it will create a fund to financially assist shops that were impacted by the riots.

Lawmakers clash over where the blame lies

Lecornu has blamed far-left agitators for the unrest. "There is, after all, a far-left movement that wants to cause—we can’t put it any more strongly—profound unrest in the country in the run-up to the presidential election," he said.

Jean-Luc Mélenchon, leader of France’s far-left party, France Unbowed, pushed back against this framing and insisted the protest movement is “the result of ten disastrous years in which President Macron has disorganized the state and public services.” TIME has reached out to Macron’s offices for comment.

The discord between lawmakers and the uncertainty in the government with Nuñez’s resignation attempt hanging over the proceedings comes just six months ahead of France’s next presidential election, where Mélenchon will no doubt be hoping to beat centrist contenders to the runoff.

France’s public debt has climbed to a record $4 trillion in Macron’s two terms, according to figures shared by France’s National

Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies in late June. The fiscal dilemma has heightened scrutiny on government spending and has sparked questions over “Macronisme,” the right-of-center, top-down governing style that Macron emulates. Further adding to the economic pressures, French government bonds dropped after the weekend of unrest.

Antonio Fatas, a professor of economics at Insead, the European business school, has said the political and economic situation is serious. “I am very worried about the economic situation because growth is low and it is difficult to see how the dynamics change. Then you have the debt numbers, which are bad, and the financial markets are thinking the government is not in control,” he told the *Guardian*.

People vandalize a shop during protests in Milan, Italy, on Oct. 18, 2026.Andrea Carrubba—Getty Images

Teachers stand between anti riot Police and students at Piazza Castello in the center of Turin during the 'No Meloni Day', a national day of marches across Italy inspired by what is happening in France and Spain, to protest against the cost of living, the School Decree, the condition of school buildings and demanding increased funding, on Oct. 16, 2026.Marco Bertorello—AFP/Getty Images

Demonstrations spread across France

Throughout September, students across France blockaded schools and demonstrated against, what they say is, a poorly-funded high school system. The protests went nationwide on Oct. 6, when more than 250,000 people took to streets across the country with teachers, parents, and union activists joining marches.

The demonstrations have drawn comparisons to the May 1968 protests, which were initiated by a student movement and led to millions of workers striking and nearly toppled the government.

In the years since, there have been numerous protest uprisings in Paris, including the Yellow Vest movement of 2018 and the pension reform protests of 2023.

What distinguishes the unrest that unfolded over the weekend is how the pockets of violence dispersed, says Fabien Jobard, a researcher at the French National Centre for Scientific Research. He says that the rioters moved away from the main demonstrations, seemingly catching the police off guard and making it all the more

difficult to contain the unrest. That, coupled with the French authorities' own admittance of failing to anticipate the full scale of the protests, meant that "it was too late to gather enough police forces in different places," adds Jobard.

On Saturday, as some sought to revive the Yellow Vest movement, protesters draped a yellow vest over the Marianne statue at the Place de la République.

The group that helped coordinate the action on its website described the mobilization as a convergence of student protests and wider economic grievances, bringing together high school and university students, farmers, firefighters, workers, teachers, healthcare workers, climate activists, residents of working-class neighborhoods, and retirees.

Alongside concerns over school funding and cost-of-living pressures, there is mounting backlash over fuel prices, which have significantly increased since the onset of the Iran war due to continued disruption in the Strait of Hormuz.

Obradovich describes it as an "intersectional protest movement," arguing that "the root of all of these problems boils down to this government system taking away funding from public services."

In his speech addressing the nation, Macron said order must be restored, but also recognized protesters' concerns. He said his government was working with fuel distributors to ensure a "tangible impact on prices." He added that the voices of young people "must be heard" and referenced how the Minister of National Education had set up an online portal where students can share their ideas to improve the education system.

Albanian riot police detain a demonstrator during renewed clashes outside the Ministry of Education in Tirana, Albania, on Oct. 18, 2026.Vlasov Sulaj—NurPhoto/Getty Image

Thousands protest in other European cities

France was not alone in dealing with demonstrations over the weekend, as protesters also took to the streets in other European countries.

In Portugal, protesters marched in Lisbon, Porto, and Coimbra as they called for better pensions, improved public services, and affirmative government action to combat rising living costs.

In Milan, police clashed with protesters as some threw stones and looted shops during demonstrations against underfunded services and the rising cost of living.

Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni condemned "the violence of criminals who, even through organized groups, exploit demonstrations to seek confrontation and sow chaos." There were further clashes between police and protesters in Bologna and Turin.

Unrest also broke out in Brussels, Belgium, on Saturday afternoon, as antifascist activists took to the streets. The demonstrations

turned violent, prompting police intervention amid reports of property damage.

In Albania, protests spilled over to a sixth day on Sunday, with student-led demonstrations marching against, what they argue is, an underfunded education system, and allegations of government corruption. Police and protesters clashed in the capital of Tirana, as Prime Minister Edi Rama staunchly rejected calls for his resignation.

Albania’s current demonstrations come months after a protest movement rallied against a planned luxury development linked to Jared Kushner, U.S. President Donald Trump’s son-in-law. The initial marches in May were borne out of environmental concerns, but protests developed amid allegations of corruption and discontent over cost-of-living pressures.

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/19/how-protests-in-france-europe-spiraled-out-of-control/

World | Ukraine

What Is Starshield, SpaceX's Military Version of Starlink, and Why Is It So Important to Ukraine?

Ukrainian servicemen walk along a road to military positions in Donetsk Oblast, Ukraine, on Aug. 22, 2026.Alex Nikitenko/Global Images Ukraine—Getty Images

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Narrated by TIME AI.

Ukrainian forces said Wednesday its battlefield efforts had been hampered overnight after losing some access to SpaceX’s military-grade satellite Internet service, which has become a lifeline as Kyiv weathers Moscow's attacks.

Starlink offers Internet connectivity from satellites in low-Earth orbit. Its sister service Starshield, a military version developed for the Pentagon, relies on the Starlink network and has recently been used by Ukrainian forces to strengthen its far-reaching drone strike missions and air defenses.

Serhiy Beskrestnov, a military technology expert who advises Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky, said speed restrictions had been imposed on the "military package" of Starshield services, leading to the “failure” of several military missions. “Our defense forces have not received any warnings about this restriction,” he said. Beskrestnov claimed the restrictions, which he said applied to devices traveling over 100 miles per hour and using Starshield, were “related to the current political situation.” He did not offer further details.

Tensions are high between the U.S. and Ukraine, as Zelensky has been vocal in his disapproval of U.S. President Donald Trump’s plan to import diesel from Russia, despite previous sanctions prohibiting it. The move has also caused a split in Trump’s own party, with several Republican lawmakers urging him to reverse course. After making the deal with Russian President Vladimir Putin last week, Trump announced an “energy cease-fire” between Russia and Ukraine—but Zelensky swiftly accused Moscow of violating any such agreement and Ukraine has, in turn, resumed strikes on Russian oil refineries, despite pressure from Washington. Trump called Ukraine's fresh wave of strikes on Russian refineries a "disgrace" in an interview that aired Thursday.

Speaking from the U.K., Zelensky said Wednesday it was a “pity” Ukrainian forces had experienced “difficulties” with Starlink services and intelligence, adding that he was surprised by the developments in Ukraine’s partnership with the U.S. In an interview on *Piers Morgan Uncensored*, Zelensky suggested he believed Starlink had been slowed down to damage him. But he later added that he hoped the restriction was only a “mistake,” suggesting it was perhaps "a huge technical problem” at SpaceX.

However, in another interview, Zelensky said: "It was not a technical problem, it was the will.”

SpaceX founder and CEO Elon Musk addressed the matter, insisting that Starlink and Starshield are different. He cited the U.S. authorities as being in control of the latter's usage determinations.

"Starshield systems are owned and controlled by the U.S. government. Any limits on speed or usage are decided by the U.S. military and ultimately POTUS," he said on X. "Starlink is a commercial service owned and controlled by SpaceX. Usage of Starlink is limited to civilian or defensive activities and cannot be used for offensive military action, as doing so would be inappropriate for a commercial company."

When approached for comment, a senior U.S. official told TIME: "No such request was ever made by the President."

Reuters, citing three U.S. officials, later reported that the decision came from inside the White House.

TIME has reached out to the White House for further comment.

Meanwhile, Ukrainian national news agency Ukrinform reported Thursday, citing sources within the Ministry of Defense, that the Starshield service had resumed. TIME has reached out to Ukraine's Ministry of Defense for comment.

The discourse has raised questions about what Starshield is and how uniquely important it has become on the Ukrainian battlefield.

What is Starshield?

Starshield is a program developed by Musk's SpaceX that draws on the satellite and launch capability behind Starlink, its commercial satellite Internet network, to support national security operations.

According to SpaceX, Starshield is designed for government use, with an initial focus on three areas: Earth observation,

communications, and hosted payloads.

“Starlink is basic interconnectivity, it's like the Internet. Starshield essentially grows out of the experience of Starlink,” Mark Hilborne, a senior lecturer in defense studies at King’s College London, tells TIME.

But the military value of that connectivity extends far beyond access to the Internet, Hilborne adds.

“In and of itself, satellite communications are not military technology, but it enables the military to communicate and amass a real-time, multi-domain picture of the battlefield, which some argue nobody else actually has at this stage,” he says.

Both systems also offer high-speed connectivity because of the satellite technology underpinning them.

“Starlink and Starshield are low on the Earth’s orbit, and they have a very high bandwidth, so lots of information can pass through those satellites, with virtually no delay on the signal,” Hilborne says.

There are more than 10,000 satellites in the Starlink network, while Hilborne says Starshield uses “a much smaller number of satellites.” However, the exact number of satellites associated with Starshield remains unknown, with experts telling TIME that such details are closely guarded due to national security considerations.

“They keep the contracting details on these things classified,” says Todd Harrison, a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute.

SpaceX, on its website, says Starshield is “designed to support U.S. National Defense use cases for the Department of Defense and other government partners.”

How is Starshield different from Starlink?

While both systems rely on closely related satellite technology, they differ in the services they provide and how they are intended to be used.

“Starshield refers to military services that actually operate through Starlink,” Harrison explains, comparing the services to “two different brands of a cell phone provider, even though your phone calls are going through the same towers.”

Starshield offers additional capabilities designed for military operations, including more advanced encryption and satellite imaging, experts tell TIME.

“It's got another extra set of capabilities over and above Starlink,” Hilborne says. “They use some of the same technologies, but it would be highly encrypted, and they have different sensors that allow them to image what they call ‘Earth observation.’ That can give a radar imaging of the Earth [which] has advantages over optical pictures.”

Yet experts say the distinction between the two systems is not always clear, particularly given how closely their underlying technology and operations are connected.

How important is Starshield for Ukraine?

Starshield and the satellite communications technology underpinning it have become vital to Ukraine’s military operations against Russia.

Hilborne describes the technology as “highly critical” to Ukraine, explaining that any restrictions could cut communications with military equipment traveling above that speed, leaving operators

without the information needed to guide their missions, as once that speed threshold is exceeded, the connection “suddenly cuts off and it's flying blind,” he says.

The consequences are particularly serious for Ukrainian drone operations, which rely on communications for both strikes against Russian targets and defensive missions against incoming attacks.

“It's really critical for drones, both the offensive medium range strikes, but also affects Ukraine's ability to fly defensive drones against the incoming Russian drones,” says Hilborne.

Beyond its role in drone missions, experts say satellite communications also offer important advantages over other forms of battlefield connectivity.

Harrison notes that “the big benefit of using satellite-based communications is that you can communicate over longer distances in a variety of terrain, and it does have some jam-resistant features to overcome electronic forms of attack.”

Underlining its importance, Zelensky said on *Piers Morgan Uncensored* that “people will die” if attacks from Russia continue while Ukraine’s Starshield access is limited.

Europe has looked for alternatives to assist Kyiv, but nothing on the market compares.

“Starlink is really necessary for Ukraine,” said E.U. foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas. “Unfortunately, in the short term, Europe can’t replace this capability.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/10/15/what-is-starshield-spacex-military-version-starlink-restrictions-ukraine-battlefield/